

ENGLISH FOR CLIENT ENGAGEMENTS

Consulting English

Clarify the question. Make the recommendation usable.

Phil Stilwell

© 2026 Phil Stilwell. All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means without prior written permission from the author, except as permitted by law.



Eight scenarios. Eight extended conversations.

INSIDE THE BOOK

192 vocabulary entries / 128 reusable phrases

160 dialogue turns / 80 numbered dialogue gaps

Word banks and explained answer keys

Upper-intermediate to advanced (B2-C1). For consultants, engagement managers, analysts, client-facing specialists, and internal advisory teams.

2026 edition

Eight scenarios. Eight skills.

Eight engagement conversations: define the real decision, challenge a favored hypothesis, prioritize a data request, build an executive storyline, manage additional scope, respond to corrective feedback, prepare adoption, and close a steering meeting with an accurate decision record.

01 Client Discovery and Problem Definition

4

The requested study is not the decision | Turn a request for benchmarking into an agreed decision question with boundaries, criteria, and an owner.

02 Hypotheses and Issue Trees

13

A frequent complaint is not yet the cause of churn | Use a working hypothesis to organize analysis while checking alternative explanations, overlapping categories, and evidence that could contradict it.

03 Data Requests and Client Burden

22

Forty requests, but only six are needed first | Prioritize a client data request, define the required measures, and agree a feasible delivery sequence without collecting unnecessary personal information.

04 Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

31

Twelve charts need one clear decision request | Convert an analytical presentation into a supported recommendation with a specific request, visible limits, and an agreed test.

05 Scope Management and Change Requests

40

A second market is a new request, not a free extension | Respond constructively to additional work by distinguishing the agreed scope from the proposed change and explaining options without premature commitments.

06 Difficult Client Feedback

49

The recommendation depends on staff the client does not have | Acknowledge a missed constraint, restate its effect on the recommendation, and agree a credible correction without becoming defensive or promising an untested solution.

07 Implementation and Change Management

58

Receiving the launch email is not readiness | Explain implementation readiness using training, observed practice, operational cover, and ownership rather than treating communication as adoption.

08 Steering Committees and Final Readouts

67

Agreement on the problem is not approval of an option | Close a divided decision meeting by summarizing trade-offs, distinguishing agreement from authorization, and recording the actual decision and owned follow-ups.

Communication field notes

3

Answers and explanations

76

Fast-access phrase pages

92

Vocabulary index

94

Sources and publication notes

102

A clear point of view. A traceable basis.

Consultants need to be concise without disguising uncertainty, helpful without promising unlimited scope, and confident without treating a working hypothesis as a fact. These cases practice the language of real client work, from the first discovery conversation to the final decision.

Ask what the work will decide

A requested analysis is often a means, not the business decision itself. Clarify the choice, owner, criteria, and deadline before collecting a large amount of information.

"What decision should the benchmarking study help you make?"

Test the attractive explanation

A plausible story can organize analysis, but it must remain open to evidence against it. Separate a proposed explanation from an established finding.

"Price is a working hypothesis; we have not yet ruled out service or competitor changes."

Make the implication visible

Executives need to know why a finding matters for their choice. Connect the evidence to a bounded recommendation and an explicit request, without hiding material limitations in supporting pages.

"The evidence supports a limited pilot, not a full rollout today."

Own revisions without inventing agreement

A missed constraint deserves a direct acknowledgment and a revised analysis. A positive discussion does not equal approval, and agreement on the problem does not settle the option.

"We agree on the problem, but the preferred option remains undecided."

PROFESSIONAL BOUNDARIES

All clients, engagements, people, figures, contracts, policies, and decisions are fictional. This is professional English practice, not legal, financial, statistical, or implementation advice. Real decisions require the applicable evidence, contractual terms, approvals, and qualified review. The cited organizations do not endorse this book.

The requested study is not the decision

A Read the situation

Turn a request for benchmarking into an agreed decision question with boundaries, criteria, and an owner.

Client sponsor Rita asks consultant Owen for a benchmark of support-center costs. During discovery, she explains that the executive committee must decide by 30 November whether to centralize the North and South support centers or retain them separately. The comparison must address total operating cost, response time, and service continuity, including transition effects. Staffing and customer-impact data are not yet available. Centralization has not been approved. Owen must define the decision and evidence needs before treating a peer cost comparison as a recommendation to close either site.

PEOPLE / Rita: Client sponsor | Owen: Engagement lead

CLARIFICATION CAN BE A FORM OF SERVICE

Questioning a requested deliverable can sound obstructive if it is detached from the client objective. Explain how the clarification makes the work more useful, then confirm the decision in the client language. Avoid implying that the sponsor asked a foolish question.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What must the executive committee decide?

- A** Whether to centralize the two centers or retain them separately
- C** Whether benchmarking is forbidden

- B** Which center has already been approved for closure
- D** Which consultant should approve staffing changes

2. When is the decision needed?

- A** By 30 November
- C** Immediately without evidence

- B** After an unspecified annual review
- D** Only after both sites close

3. Which criteria belong in the comparison?

- A** Cost, response time, and service continuity, including transition effects
- C** Only the presentation length

- B** Peer cost alone
- D** Only the consultant's preferred operating model

[Answers and explanations: page 76.](#)

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

discovery

Early inquiry to understand the client situation and decision.

IN USE conduct client discovery

problem statement

A precise description of the question or issue to address.

IN USE refine the problem statement

decision question

The choice that the analysis is intended to support.

IN USE define the decision question

client sponsor

The client representative supporting and directing the engagement within their role.

IN USE align with the client sponsor

decision owner

The person or body authorized to make the relevant choice.

IN USE identify the decision owner

benchmark

A reference used for a defined comparison.

IN USE establish a benchmark

peer group

Organizations or units selected for comparison.

IN USE define the peer group

comparability

The degree to which a comparison uses sufficiently similar definitions and conditions.

IN USE assess comparability

operating model

How an organization arranges people, processes, systems, and responsibilities.

IN USE compare operating models

centralization

Concentrating specified activities or authority in a common location or structure.

IN USE evaluate centralization

decentralization

Distributing specified activities or authority across units.

IN USE assess decentralization

baseline

The defined starting position used for comparison.

IN USE establish the baseline

Precision check

A benchmark compares selected measures against a reference group. It does not itself decide the operating model. Different service hours, case complexity, or cost definitions can make apparently similar figures misleading unless the comparison is adjusted or qualified.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

decision criterion

A factor used to evaluate alternatives.

IN USE agree decision criteria

constraint

A limit that an option must respect or explicitly address.

IN USE surface a constraint

service continuity

Maintaining the required service through an operating change.

IN USE assess service continuity

transition cost

A cost associated with moving from one arrangement to another.

IN USE estimate transition costs

steady-state cost

Cost after a defined transition has settled.

IN USE compare steady-state costs

response time

Elapsed time to provide a specified response.

IN USE define response time

stakeholder map

A representation of relevant parties and their interests or roles.

IN USE build a stakeholder map

in-scope

Included in the agreed work boundaries.

IN USE confirm what is in scope

out-of-scope

Excluded from the agreed work boundaries.

IN USE identify out-of-scope work

success measure

A defined indicator of whether the intended result has been achieved.

IN USE agree success measures

engagement charter

A document summarizing purpose, boundaries, roles, and arrangements.

IN USE confirm the engagement charter

decision deadline

The date or time by which a choice is needed.

IN USE work to the decision deadline

Precision check

Separate steady-state cost from transition cost and disruption. A centralized model might look attractive after implementation while creating an unacceptable transition problem. The exercise does not establish which option is superior; it establishes the question the engagement must answer.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

CLARIFY THE PURPOSE

"What decision should this benchmark help you make?"

CONFIRM THE OWNER

"The executive committee owns that decision."

KEEP THE OPTION OPEN

"Centralization has not been approved."

SEPARATE COST TYPES

"Show transition costs separately from steady-state costs."

STATE THE REAL CHOICE

"The choice is centralization or continued separate operation."

CONFIRM THE DATE

"The recommendation needs to support the thirtieth-of-November decision."

IDENTIFY THE CRITERIA

"We need to compare cost, response time, and service continuity."

CHECK COMPARABILITY

"Are the peer figures based on comparable services and definitions?"

Should help

Connects the requested analysis to its intended purpose.

The choice is

States alternatives without selecting one prematurely.

Has not been approved

Prevents exploration becoming an implied commitment.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

NAME AN EVIDENCE GAP

"We do not yet have the staffing and customer-impact data."

SET THE BOUNDARY

"This phase evaluates options; it does not authorize implementation."

REFLECT THE REQUEST

"The benchmark is one input to the operating-model decision."

CHECK UNDERSTANDING

"Is that the choice you need the analysis to support?"

AVOID A PREMATURE CONCLUSION

"A lower peer cost would not by itself justify closing a site."

ASK ABOUT CONSTRAINTS

"Which service requirements must remain intact during transition?"

CONFIRM THE DELIVERABLE

"We will produce a decision-focused option comparison."

CLOSE DISCOVERY

"Let us record the question, criteria, owner, deadline, and evidence needs."

By itself

Limits what one piece of evidence can establish.

One input

Positions benchmarking within a wider decision.

Let us record

Turns a verbal clarification into a shared reference.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which problem statement fits the brief?

- A** How many slides will impress the committee?
- B** Which peer cost proves centralization is always best?
- C** Should North and South be centralized, given cost, response time, continuity, and transition effects?
- D** How can we justify the already approved closure?

2. Which benchmark caveat matters?

- A** A familiar company needs no definition checks.
- B** Peer service scope and cost definitions may differ.
- C** All peer figures are automatically comparable.
- D** A cost ratio determines every customer effect.

3. What does the evidence gap mean?

- A** The consultant may invent the missing figures.
- B** Staffing and customer-impact information is still needed.
- C** Centralization is necessarily wrong.
- D** Separate operation is necessarily wrong.

4. Which phrase preserves engagement authority?

- A** This phase evaluates options; implementation requires a separate authorized decision.
- B** Discovery automatically authorizes closure.
- C** The consultant replaces the executive committee.
- D** Asking for a benchmark commits the client to centralization.

[Answers and explanations: page 76.](#)

The requested study is not the decision

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

decision owner / baseline / in-scope / decision criteria / decision deadline / transition cost / engagement charter / comparability / decision question / peer group

- 01 **Rita:** We would like a benchmark of support-center costs. The committee keeps asking whether we are spending more than comparable organizations.
- 02 **Owen:** Before we define the ¹ _____, what decision should the benchmark help you make? That will determine which comparisons are useful and which would simply add more numbers.
- 03 **Rita:** We need to decide whether North and South should become one centralized support operation or continue running separately.
- 04 **Owen:** Then our ² _____ is about the operating model. The cost benchmark is an input, but we should not let it silently become a recommendation to close either site.
- 05 **Rita:** Agreed. Nothing has been approved. The executive committee needs a recommendation by the thirtieth of November.
- 06 **Owen:** I will record that ³ _____. We should also confirm who will supply information and when the committee needs material for its own review before that date.
- 07 **Rita:** Cost matters, but we also need acceptable response times and continuity. A cheap arrangement that interrupts service would not solve the problem.
- 08 **Owen:** Those are our ⁴ _____. We need definitions for each, so the team does not optimize a cost measure while overlooking the service requirements the committee actually values.
- 09 **Rita:** The transition could be difficult even if the centralized model eventually operates at a lower cost. We do not have those figures yet.
- 10 **Owen:** Separate ⁵ _____ from the steady-state comparison. We should show temporary effects and ongoing costs distinctly, rather than present a future operating estimate as the whole business case.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 10.

- 11 **Rita:** The peer organizations may handle different types of support requests. Some provide fewer service hours than we do.
- 12 **Owen:** That affects ⁶ _____. We need matching definitions or visible qualifications. A lower cost elsewhere does not tell us that either of your centers is inefficient under the same conditions.
- 13 **Rita:** I can arrange access to the current service figures. Staffing and customer-impact information will take longer to obtain.
- 14 **Owen:** Let us establish the ⁷ _____ and list those gaps. We can plan the evidence work without filling missing figures with assumptions that look like confirmed client data.
- 15 **Rita:** Should the initial work include a detailed implementation plan, or would that get ahead of the decision?
- 16 **Owen:** We should define what is ⁸ _____. The option comparison needs transition implications, but a full implementation plan is a separate level of work that we should not assume is included.
- 17 **Rita:** The committee will make the choice. I can sponsor the engagement and coordinate the inputs, but I cannot approve a closure myself.
- 18 **Owen:** That clarifies the ⁹ _____. We can direct the recommendation to the committee and ask you to confirm the factual inputs and engagement arrangements within your role.
- 19 **Rita:** Please summarize the question, boundaries, criteria, and dates so that everyone starts with the same understanding.
- 20 **Owen:** I will put them in the ¹⁰ _____. Then the benchmark serves the actual choice, and the team has a clear basis for deciding what evidence to collect first.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 77

1. peer group | 2. decision question | 3. decision deadline | 4. decision criteria | 5. transition cost | 6. comparability | 7. baseline | 8. in-scope | 9. decision owner | 10. engagement charter

Clarify a different requested study

F Say it

A sponsor requests a vendor-price comparison. The actual choice is whether to renew the current provider or run a new competition. The procurement committee decides by 15 January, using total cost, service performance, and transition risk.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

a new competition / 15 January / transition risk / procurement committee

Consultant: "The actual alternatives are renewal or ¹ _____."

Sponsor: "The decision owner is the ² _____."

Consultant: "The decision deadline is ³ _____."

Sponsor: "The comparison must include total cost, performance, and ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 77

1. a new competition | 2. procurement committee | 3. 15 January | 4. transition risk

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Check your answers, then read turns 1-10 with a partner using the corrected words.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress words that distinguish facts from conditions or estimates.
3. Complete and check the four-line exchange. Read it twice, switching roles and keeping the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

A frequent complaint is not yet the cause of churn

A Read the situation

Use a working hypothesis to organize analysis while checking alternative explanations, overlapping categories, and evidence that could contradict it.

A client lost 60 accounts last quarter. Twenty departing customers volunteered for interviews: 12 mentioned price, 9 mentioned service delays, and 5 mentioned competitor features. Each person could mention more than one issue. Consultant Ada wants to lead with price as the cause of churn; manager Karim asks for a testable hypothesis and a structured inquiry into the alternatives. The interview sample is not established as representative. Timing, customer segments, actual prices paid, and comparable nondeparting accounts have not yet been analyzed. No causal driver has been isolated.

PEOPLE / Ada: Consultant | Karim: Engagement manager

CHALLENGE THE LOGIC, NOT THE ANALYST

A sharp question about an explanation can improve the work without rejecting the person who proposed it. State which part is useful, then ask what would weaken it. A team that can revise its first answer is more credible than one that protects it from contrary evidence.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. How many departing accounts were interviewed?

- A Twenty-six distinct accounts
- C All sixty accounts

- B Twenty of the sixty departing accounts
- D Twenty current nondeparting accounts only

2. Why do the mentions add to more than twenty?

- A Respondents could mention multiple issues.
- C Each mention proves a separate departure.

- B The interview count must be fraudulent.
- D The percentages use all sixty departures.

3. What has the team established about causation?

- A Competitor features cannot matter.
- C Price caused every departure.

- B No causal driver has been isolated.
- D Service had no effect.

Answers and explanations: page 78.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

hypothesis

A proposed explanation that can be examined against evidence.

IN USE test a hypothesis

issue tree

A structured breakdown of a question into related subquestions.

IN USE build an issue tree

hypothesis tree

A breakdown of a proposed explanation into testable supporting claims.

IN USE develop a hypothesis tree

workstream

A coordinated part of the engagement's work.

IN USE assign a workstream

churn

Customer or account loss, defined over a specified period and population.

IN USE analyze account churn

churn driver

A factor contributing to customer departure.

IN USE investigate churn drivers

exit interview

A conversation with someone leaving a service or organization.

IN USE conduct exit interviews

multi-response question

A question allowing more than one answer category.

IN USE interpret a multi-response question

mention count

The number of recorded references to a specified topic.

IN USE report mention counts

sample

The observations included in an analysis.

IN USE define the sample

sampling bias

Distortion associated with how observations enter a sample.

IN USE assess sampling bias

MECE

Mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive; a structuring aim of avoiding overlap and missing categories.

IN USE test a MECE structure

Precision check

Twelve of twenty interviewees mentioned price: 60% of that interview group. It is not evidence that price caused 60% of all sixty departures. The price, service, and competitor counts overlap because respondents could give more than one answer.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

overlap

Inclusion of the same observation in more than one category.

IN USE identify category overlap

double counting

Counting the same item more than intended in a total.

IN USE prevent double counting

alternative explanation

A different possible account of an observed result.

IN USE test alternative explanations

disconfirming evidence

Information that weakens or contradicts a hypothesis.

IN USE seek disconfirming evidence

confirmation bias

Favoring information that supports an existing belief.

IN USE challenge confirmation bias

causal mechanism

The process through which one factor could produce an effect.

IN USE specify the causal mechanism

segmentation

Dividing a population into defined groups for analysis.

IN USE use customer segmentation

cohort

A group sharing a defined starting characteristic or period.

IN USE compare customer cohorts

price sensitivity

Responsiveness to price changes under specified conditions.

IN USE examine price sensitivity

confounder

Another factor that complicates a proposed causal interpretation.

IN USE examine potential confounders

triangulation

Comparing different evidence sources or methods.

IN USE triangulate the finding

analytical priority

A question selected for attention based on decision relevance and evidence needs.

IN USE set analytical priorities

Precision check

MECE is an organizing aim, not a label that makes real-world causes independent. A customer can experience both a price increase and a service failure. Define how observations are coded, and avoid forcing a multi-cause account into a false single-cause total.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

KEEP THE EXPLANATION PROVISIONAL

"Price is a working hypothesis, not an established churn driver."

LIMIT THE PERCENTAGE

"Twelve of those twenty interviewees mentioned price."

AVOID A FALSE TOTAL

"The categories are not mutually exclusive."

TEST THE ALTERNATIVE

"We also need to examine service experience and competitor changes."

STATE THE SAMPLE

"We interviewed twenty of the sixty departing accounts."

EXPLAIN OVERLAP

"Respondents could name more than one issue."

ASK FOR A MECHANISM

"How would the proposed price effect lead to departure?"

LOOK FOR CONTRADICTION

"What evidence would weaken the price hypothesis?"

Working hypothesis

Gives the team a testable starting point rather than a fixed conclusion.

Those twenty

Keeps the denominator tied to the interview sample.

Could name more than one

Explains why categories overlap.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

CHECK TIMING

"Did the price change precede the departure?"

SEGMENT THE EVIDENCE

"Separate the patterns by relevant customer group."

AVOID A CAUSAL SHORTCUT

"A frequent complaint does not by itself isolate a cause."

REVISE OPENLY

"The new evidence may require us to change the initial explanation."

COMPARE CAREFULLY

"How do otherwise comparable nondeparting accounts differ?"

CHECK ACTUAL EXPOSURE

"Use prices actually paid, not only the published list price."

PRIORITIZE THE WORK

"Start with questions that could change the client decision."

CLOSE THE ANALYSIS PLAN

"Assign a test, evidence source, and owner to each priority question."

Would weaken

Actively invites evidence against the preferred explanation.

Actually paid

Distinguishes realized prices from advertised prices.

Could change the decision

Uses relevance rather than analytical convenience to set priorities.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which finding is supported?

- A** All sixty departing customers answered the interview.
- B** The three categories cover separate people only.
- C** Twelve of twenty volunteer interviewees mentioned price.
- D** Price caused 60% of all departures.

2. Which follow-up best tests rather than protects the hypothesis?

- A** Exclude every interview mentioning service.
- B** Treat a senior colleague's confidence as proof.
- C** Stop collecting evidence once price is mentioned.
- D** Examine whether comparable accounts with similar price changes stayed.

3. How should the issue categories be presented?

- A** As mutually exclusive simply because the slide says MECE
- B** As percentages of an unstated population
- C** As overlapping mentions, with the coding method explained
- D** As 26 unique departures from 20 interviews

4. What makes an analytical priority useful?

- A** It confirms the first theory by definition.
- B** It eliminates all uncertainty without data.
- C** It could change the decision and has an explicit evidence test.
- D** It is the easiest chart to produce.

Answers and explanations: page 78.

A frequent complaint is not yet the cause of churn

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

causal mechanism / hypothesis / analytical priority / overlap / disconfirming evidence / triangulation / sample / segmentation / issue tree / MECE

- 01 **Ada:** Price came up most often in the exit interviews. I was going to make price the main cause of churn in the first client update.
- 02 **Karim:** Make it a ¹ _____, not a finding about cause. We have twenty volunteer interviews from sixty departures, and the way people entered that sample could affect what we hear.
- 03 **Ada:** Twelve mentioned price, nine mentioned service delays, and five mentioned competitor features. The total is greater than twenty because people could mention several issues.
- 04 **Karim:** Then disclose the ² _____. Those are topic mentions, not separate groups of departing accounts. A clean-looking chart must not imply that the categories are mutually exclusive when they are not.
- 05 **Ada:** Twelve out of twenty is sixty percent. I should say sixty percent of interviewees mentioned price, not sixty percent of departures were caused by price.
- 06 **Karim:** Exactly. The ³ _____ defines that percentage. We have not established representativeness, and mentioning a concern does not isolate its causal effect on the decision to leave.
- 07 **Ada:** How should I organize the next analysis without creating a huge list of every possible reason someone might cancel?
- 08 **Karim:** Build an ⁴ _____ around questions that could change the retention decision. Include price exposure, service experience, and competitor developments, while being clear that real causes may interact.
- 09 **Ada:** We sometimes call our trees MECE. That could be misleading if we use the label to suggest that these customer experiences cannot coexist.
- 10 **Karim:** Treat ⁵ _____ as a structuring check, not a substitute for understanding the data. Define the coding and identify gaps or overlaps instead of forcing complex departures into artificial single-cause boxes.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 19.

- 11 **Ada:** For price, we could check the amounts customers actually paid and whether a change occurred before cancellation.
- 12 **Karim:** That begins to test a ⁶ _____. Timing matters, and list prices may differ from actual exposure because of discounts or contract terms. We should not assume every account faced the same change.
- 13 **Ada:** We should also look at customers who stayed despite similar price changes, rather than only accounts that support our first explanation.
- 14 **Karim:** That could provide ⁷ _____. Check comparability and relevant differences before interpreting it. The aim is to test the explanation, not select the most convenient retained accounts to prove the opposite.
- 15 **Ada:** Service delays may affect some customer groups more than others. A combined result could hide that pattern.
- 16 **Karim:** Use relevant ⁸ _____. But document how groups are defined, and do not repeatedly regroup the data just until a compelling story appears.
- 17 **Ada:** We can compare interview accounts, service records, and actual commercial terms to see where the evidence agrees or conflicts.
- 18 **Karim:** That is useful ⁹ _____. Keep discrepancies visible. Agreement across sources may strengthen an interpretation, but it does not automatically remove all alternative explanations.
- 19 **Ada:** I will revise the update to state the interview pattern and the tests needed before recommending a price response.
- 20 **Karim:** Good. Set each ¹⁰ _____ with an evidence source and owner. The initial hypothesis should help us learn faster, not make the team resistant to what the next analysis finds.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 79

1. hypothesis | 2. overlap | 3. sample | 4. issue tree | 5. MECE | 6. causal mechanism | 7. disconfirming evidence | 8. segmentation | 9. triangulation | 10. analytical priority

Interpret another overlapping interview sample

F Say it

Forty customers departed. Ten volunteered for interviews; six mentioned onboarding and five mentioned support. Multiple answers were allowed. The sample has not been shown to represent every departing customer.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

60% / overlapping mentions / ten customers / causal driver

Analyst: "The interview sample contains ¹ _____."

Manager: "Onboarding was mentioned by ² _____ of interviewees."

Analyst: "The categories contain ³ _____."

Manager: "The result does not establish a ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 79

1. ten customers | 2. 60% | 3. overlapping mentions | 4. causal driver

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Check your answers, then read turns 1-10 with a partner using the corrected words.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress words that distinguish facts from conditions or estimates.
3. Complete and check the four-line exchange. Read it twice, switching roles and keeping the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Forty requests, but only six are needed first

A Read the situation

Prioritize a client data request, define the required measures, and agree a feasible delivery sequence without collecting unnecessary personal information.

Consultant Mateo sends client lead Leah a 40-item request due Friday. The first analysis actually needs six monthly measures for January through June at the North and South centers: completed cases, paid staff hours, labor cost, vendor cost, reopened cases, and opening backlog. That analysis is needed for a Wednesday workshop. Existing aggregate reports may be sufficient, but definitions and period coverage must be checked. The remaining 34 items have not been prioritized. Leah cannot promise the full request. Mateo must agree owners, feasible dates, and approved transfer arrangements rather than demand raw personal records by default.

PEOPLE / Mateo: Consultant | Leah: Client data lead

CLIENT EFFORT IS PART OF THE WORK PLAN

A data request competes with the daily responsibilities of the client team. Explain which decision each priority item supports, accept existing formats when suitable, and negotiate dates with the people doing the work. Labeling every item urgent usually makes genuine priorities harder to recognize.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. How many items are required for the first analysis?

A Thirty-four

C Six

B None

D All forty

2. Which period is required?

A One total with no period definition

C Only the latest Friday

B Every year of personal records

D January through June, monthly, for both centers

3. What is the timing problem?

A Friday is necessarily too early for every item.

C Data definitions no longer matter because of the deadline.

B The workshop has already approved all data.

D A Friday deadline is later than the Wednesday workshop that needs the analysis.

Answers and explanations: page 80.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

03

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

data request list

A documented set of information items requested for an analysis.

IN USE prioritize the data request list

DRL

Data request list, with items, owners, definitions, and delivery status.

IN USE update the DRL

minimum viable dataset

The smallest adequate set of information for a defined initial analysis.

IN USE define the minimum viable dataset

data owner

The person or function responsible for the relevant information.

IN USE identify the data owner

extract

A selected set of information taken from a source system.

IN USE prepare a data extract

aggregate

Information combined into defined groups rather than individual records.

IN USE use monthly aggregates

granularity

The level of detail represented in the data.

IN USE agree the required granularity

reporting period

The time interval covered by a measure.

IN USE specify the reporting period

data dictionary

Definitions of fields, units, and relevant rules.

IN USE request a data dictionary

field definition

The meaning and permitted interpretation of a data item.

IN USE confirm field definitions

unit of measure

The scale or quantity in which a value is expressed.

IN USE preserve the unit of measure

coverage

The population, locations, or periods included.

IN USE check period coverage

Precision check

A smaller first request is not a waiver of definitions or quality. Confirm what completed, reopened, and opening mean in the existing reports, along with units, cost scope, and monthly coverage. A timely file with misunderstood fields can produce a misleading comparison.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

03

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

completeness

Whether the required information is present.

IN USE assess completeness

reconciliation

A comparison used to explain or resolve differences between records.

IN USE reconcile source totals

source system

The originating application or record for data.

IN USE identify the source system

secure transfer

An approved method for moving information with appropriate protection.

IN USE arrange secure transfer

access permission

Authorization to view or use specified information.

IN USE confirm access permissions

personal data

Information relating to an identifiable individual under the applicable context.

IN USE limit personal data

data minimization

Restricting collection to information necessary for the stated purpose.

IN USE apply data minimization

request dependency

A condition that must be met before a requested item can be delivered or used.

IN USE identify request dependencies

delivery sequence

The order in which information will be provided.

IN USE agree the delivery sequence

staged request

A request divided into prioritized batches.

IN USE use a staged request

exception log

A record of missing, changed, or unresolved items.

IN USE maintain an exception log

version identifier

A label distinguishing one version of a file or dataset.

IN USE record the version identifier

Precision check

Aggregate reporting may answer the first question without individual records. Verify suitability and approved access rather than requesting personal data for possible future use. Where an item cannot arrive in time, state the effect on the analysis instead of quietly substituting a different measure.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

03

ACKNOWLEDGE THE BURDEN

"The original list did not distinguish what we need first."

SPECIFY THE PERIOD

"We need monthly figures from January through June for both centers."

CHECK THE DETAIL LEVEL

"Monthly aggregates may be sufficient for this question."

CHECK COST SCOPE

"Do the labor and vendor figures cover the same operating boundary?"

EXPLAIN THE PRIORITY

"Six measures support the first workshop analysis."

USE EXISTING WORK

"Can the existing reports supply those measures?"

DEFINE THE MEASURE

"What does completed case mean in this report?"

ASSIGN AN OWNER

"Who can confirm the definition and supply each item?"

Did not distinguish

Acknowledges a weakness in the request without blaming the client.

Support the analysis

Explains why an item is being requested.

May be sufficient

Leaves suitability open to a definition and coverage check.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

03

NEGOTIATE A DATE

"What can realistically be available before Wednesday's workshop?"

AVOID UNNECESSARY COLLECTION

"We do not need individual personal records for this first analysis."

KEEP GAPS VISIBLE

"Please flag missing periods rather than filling them silently."

STATE AN ANALYTICAL LIMIT

"If that measure is unavailable, we will explain the limitation in the workshop."

STAGE THE REMAINDER

"We will prioritize the other thirty-four items separately."

AGREE THE TRANSFER

"Use the client-approved channel and access permissions."

TRACK THE VERSION

"Record the file version and extraction date."

CLOSE THE REQUEST

"I will circulate the agreed six-item list, owners, dates, and definitions."

Realistically

Invites a feasible commitment rather than a pressured guess.

Separately

Stops unprioritized work inheriting the first deadline.

Rather than silently

Makes an omission visible before it becomes an analytical error.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which revised request is most useful?

- A** Every personal record just in case.
- B** One unexplained total for both centers combined.
- C** Six defined monthly measures first, with agreed owners and dates; prioritize the rest separately.
- D** Forty equally urgent items with no purpose.

2. What should happen if an existing report is available?

- A** Accept every column without reading definitions.
- B** Treat its filename as proof of completeness.
- C** Check its definitions, scope, and coverage before accepting it.
- D** Reject it automatically because it is not a new extract.

3. What if a priority item cannot arrive before the workshop?

- A** Call a different field equivalent without checking.
- B** Hide the missing item from the presentation.
- C** Agree a realistic plan and state the resulting analytical limit.
- D** Fill it with invented numbers.

4. Which information-handling choice fits the first task?

- A** Assume every consultant may access every system.
- B** Use suitable aggregates through approved access and transfer arrangements.
- C** Request names and contact details without a defined need.
- D** Send raw records through any convenient public channel.

Answers and explanations: [page 80](#).

Forty requests, but only six are needed first

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

version identifier / delivery sequence / data request list / secure transfer / granularity / reconciliation / data owner / data dictionary / minimum viable dataset / exception log

- 01 **Leah:** I have your forty-item list due Friday. Several teams are involved, and I cannot promise all of it while they are closing their normal reports.
- 02 **Mateo:** You are right. The ¹ _____ did not distinguish what we need first. Only six measures support the initial analysis, and I should have separated them from the rest.
- 03 **Leah:** The workshop is Wednesday. A single Friday deadline does not help us understand what you need in time for that meeting.
- 04 **Mateo:** Let us agree a ² _____ with feasible dates. We need to know what can arrive before Wednesday and what limitations we will have if something is not available.
- 05 **Leah:** Please name the six measures. We may already have monthly reports that save the teams from producing new files.
- 06 **Mateo:** Our ³ _____ is completed cases, paid staff hours, labor cost, vendor cost, reopened cases, and opening backlog for January through June at both centers.
- 07 **Leah:** We have monthly summaries, but the two sites may define completed and reopened differently. The report labels do not explain that.
- 08 **Mateo:** We need a ⁴ _____ or equivalent definitions. Confirm what each field means and which period it covers before we compare figures that only appear to describe the same thing.
- 09 **Leah:** Would monthly totals by center be enough? Individual case records would require a different review and take longer to prepare.
- 10 **Mateo:** That ⁵ _____ may be sufficient for the first question. Let us verify the report coverage and definitions before asking for more detailed data that we do not currently need.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

03

Continue with the word bank on page 28.

- 11 **Leah:** Labor cost includes a shared-service allocation at North. I am not yet sure whether South uses the same cost boundary.
- 12 **Mateo:** Please flag that for ⁶ _____. We need the cost scope alongside the numbers. A difference in allocation rules could otherwise look like a difference in operating performance.
- 13 **Leah:** I can identify the relevant owners today. They need to confirm what can be supplied before the workshop, rather than have a date assigned without discussion.
- 14 **Mateo:** Agreed. Each ⁷ _____ should confirm the definition and feasible delivery date. We will prioritize the other thirty-four items separately once their analytical purpose is clear.
- 15 **Leah:** Our team also needs to know how the files will be shared and which consultants are authorized to see them.
- 16 **Mateo:** We will use the approved ⁸ _____ arrangements and access permissions. We do not need names or contact details for these monthly measures, so they should not be collected for this first analysis.
- 17 **Leah:** If a month is missing, should the team leave a note in the file rather than estimate it?
- 18 **Mateo:** Yes, keep an ⁹ _____. Identify the gap and its owner. We will explain its effect on the workshop analysis instead of quietly replacing it with a different period or measure.
- 19 **Leah:** Once the owners confirm the first batch, I will send the agreed files with their extraction dates.
- 20 **Mateo:** Include the ¹⁰ _____ as well. I will circulate the six-item request with definitions, owners, dates, and remaining gaps so both teams know exactly what has been agreed.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 81

1. data request list | 2. delivery sequence | 3. minimum viable dataset | 4. data dictionary | 5. granularity | 6. reconciliation | 7. data owner | 8. secure transfer | 9. exception log | 10. version identifier

Stage another information request

F Say it

03

A 25-item request contains four inputs needed for a Monday review. Existing weekly summaries may supply them. The remaining 21 items are for later analysis. Client owners must confirm definitions and realistic delivery dates.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

four inputs / Monday / definitions / twenty-one items

Consultant: "The first batch contains ¹ _____."

Client: "The first review is on ² _____."

Consultant: "The later group contains ³ _____."

Client: "Before using existing summaries, confirm their ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 81

1. four inputs | 2. Monday | 3. twenty-one items | 4. definitions

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Check your answers, then read turns 1-10 with a partner using the corrected words.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress words that distinguish facts from conditions or estimates.
3. Complete and check the four-line exchange. Read it twice, switching roles and keeping the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Twelve charts need one clear decision request

04

A Read the situation

Convert an analytical presentation into a supported recommendation with a specific request, visible limits, and an agreed test.

Analyst Jun has twelve charts about a proposed case-routing process but no clear recommendation. Engagement manager Sofia must prepare an executive discussion about a pilot. Walkthroughs suggest a possible benefit, but there is no live operating result. The proposal is a four-week pilot at one center with a \$20,000 budget request. Current median handling time is 12 minutes. Proposed success measures are a median of 10 minutes or less and an error rate no higher than 2%, using agreed definitions and eligible-case coverage. The committee is being asked to authorize the pilot, not full rollout.

PEOPLE / Jun: Analyst | Sofia: Engagement manager

CONCISE DOES NOT MEAN UNQUALIFIED

A senior audience may interrupt a long tour of the analysis to ask what it should do. Lead with the requested decision, then give the evidence and material limits. Put supporting detail in the appendix, but keep information that changes the decision visible in the main presentation.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What authorization is requested?

A A four-week, one-center pilot with a \$20,000 budget

C An unlimited implementation budget

B Immediate full rollout

D A guarantee of future savings

2. What evidence exists so far?

A A completed successful live pilot

C A proven zero-error rollout

B A verified reduction to ten minutes

D Walkthroughs suggesting a possible benefit, with no live operating result

3. What are the proposed success measures?

A Any faster case regardless of error rate

C Median handling time at most 10 minutes and error rate at most 2%

B A larger chart count

D Average time below twelve with errors ignored

Answers and explanations: page 82.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

storyline

The logical sequence connecting a presentation's messages.

IN USE build the storyline

executive synthesis

A concise integration of findings and implications for a decision.

IN USE prepare an executive synthesis

governing message

The central point organizing the supporting argument.

IN USE state the governing message

action title

A slide heading expressing its key conclusion or implication.

IN USE use an action title

exhibit

A chart, table, or other analytical display.

IN USE reference the exhibit

finding

An observation established by the analysis.

IN USE state the finding

insight

An interpretation explaining why a finding matters.

IN USE develop an insight

implication

A consequence or significance for the decision.

IN USE explain the implication

recommendation

A proposed course of action with its supporting basis.

IN USE make a recommendation

decision ask

The specific authorization or choice requested from the audience.

IN USE clarify the decision ask

supporting evidence

Information used to substantiate a statement.

IN USE present supporting evidence

evidence chain

The connection from source information through findings to a conclusion.

IN USE check the evidence chain

Precision check

Twelve minutes is the current median, not necessarily the mean. Ten minutes is a proposed threshold, not an achieved result. The 2% error guardrail needs a defined numerator, denominator, and eligible-case population so faster work does not conceal a quality problem.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

caveat

A material limitation or condition on a claim.

IN USE retain the caveat

main body

The principal part of a presentation, excluding supporting appendices.

IN USE keep limits in the main body

appendix

Supporting detail placed after the main material.

IN USE move detail to the appendix

pre-read

Material distributed for review before a meeting.

IN USE circulate the pre-read

visual hierarchy

The arrangement that signals the relative importance of displayed information.

IN USE improve the visual hierarchy

chart annotation

A note explaining a feature or limit of a chart.

IN USE add a chart annotation

denominator

The total underlying a proportion or rate.

IN USE state the denominator

median

The middle value in ordered observations, or the midpoint of two middle values.

IN USE report the median

pilot

A limited test of an approach before a wider decision.

IN USE authorize a pilot

guardrail

A defined limit intended to prevent an unacceptable side effect.

IN USE set a quality guardrail

success criterion

A specified condition used to judge the result.

IN USE agree success criteria

rollout decision

A choice about extending an approach beyond the initial test.

IN USE separate the rollout decision

Precision check

A pilot recommendation can be clear even when the eventual benefit is uncertain. Ask for the limited test, explain why the evidence justifies testing, and identify what the test must show. Do not present authorization to learn as authorization for full rollout.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

LEAD WITH THE REQUEST

"We recommend a four-week pilot at one center."

LIMIT THE AUTHORIZATION

"We are not asking for full rollout today."

EXPLAIN THE IMPLICATION

"That supports a bounded test, not a claim of proven operating improvement."

NAME THE PROPOSED THRESHOLD

"The pilot target is a median of ten minutes or less."

STATE THE AMOUNT

"The budget request is twenty thousand dollars."

STATE THE EVIDENCE LEVEL

"Walkthroughs suggest a possible benefit; live results are not yet available."

NAME THE CURRENT MEASURE

"The current median handling time is twelve minutes."

PRESERVE QUALITY

"The error rate must be no higher than two percent under the agreed definition."

Recommend

States a position without pretending the choice is already authorized.

Not asking for

Limits the immediate decision.

Suggest

Describes preliminary evidence without upgrading it to proof.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

DEFINE THE MEASUREMENT

"Specify eligible cases, the error numerator, and the denominator before launch."

CONNECT THE ARGUMENT

"What does this exhibit change about the decision?"

MOVE SUPPORTING DETAIL

"Put the calculation detail in the appendix, with a clear reference."

SEPARATE LATER DECISIONS

"A wider rollout requires a subsequent review and authorization."

IMPROVE THE HEADING

"Make the slide title state the finding, not just the chart topic."

KEEP THE CAVEAT VISIBLE

"The lack of live evidence belongs in the main presentation."

AVOID SELECTIVE EMPHASIS

"Show the quality measure alongside the speed result."

CLOSE THE PRESENTATION

"Ask the committee to approve the pilot scope, budget, and measurement plan."

Must be no higher

Establishes a proposed upper limit rather than a descriptive average.

Alongside

Prevents one favorable measure from hiding another important result.

Subsequent

Makes the later rollout decision distinct from this pilot approval.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which opening is decision-focused and accurate?

- A** Handling time has already fallen to ten minutes.
- B** We have no request but many interesting graphs.
- C** Approve a four-week, one-center pilot for \$20,000 to test the proposed process.
- D** These twelve charts prove full rollout will succeed.

2. Which statement belongs in the main presentation?

- A** A hidden claim that the pilot is already complete
- B** No live operating result is available yet.
- C** Only the file naming convention
- D** Every calculation row regardless of relevance

3. Which comparison preserves the metric?

- A** Two minutes saved on every individual case
- B** Current median 12 minutes; proposed pilot threshold at most 10 minutes
- C** Current mean 12 minutes because median means average in every sense
- D** Guaranteed ten-minute result for every case

4. What prevents speed from becoming the only success measure?

- A** Count only cases with good outcomes.
- B** Report the defined error-rate guardrail alongside handling time.
- C** Remove error data from the deck.
- D** Treat a faster median as automatic quality improvement.

Answers and explanations: [page 82](#).

Twelve charts need one clear decision request

E Conversations / turns 1-10

04

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

storyline / rollout decision / recommendation / executive synthesis / appendix / success criteria / guardrail / median / decision ask / action title

- 01 **Jun:** I have twelve charts for the committee, but the deck still feels like a tour of the analysis. The request is on the last page.
- 02 **Sofia:** Start with the ¹ _____. We want authorization for a four-week pilot at one center, with a twenty-thousand-dollar budget. The audience should not have to infer that from the exhibits.
- 03 **Jun:** Should the opening say the new routing process will reduce handling time, or is that stronger than our evidence supports?
- 04 **Sofia:** Keep the ² _____ bounded. Walkthroughs suggest a possible benefit, but there is no live operating result yet. We recommend testing the process, not claiming that the improvement has already happened.
- 05 **Jun:** Then the next page should explain why testing is reasonable and what uncertainty the pilot would address.
- 06 **Sofia:** That gives us a ³ _____. Each exhibit should serve that argument. If a chart does not affect the decision or explain the test, it probably does not need equal time in the meeting.
- 07 **Jun:** The current handling-time chart says twelve minutes. I need to label that as the median, not just call it the average.
- 08 **Sofia:** Yes, preserve the ⁴ _____. The proposed threshold is ten minutes or less on the same defined measure. Do not make a target sound like an achieved result or a promise about every individual case.
- 09 **Jun:** The error measure is on a separate page. The committee might hear the faster-time target and miss the quality condition.
- 10 **Sofia:** Bring the ⁵ _____ alongside it. The proposed error rate must be no higher than two percent under the agreed definition. Faster work is not enough if quality deteriorates beyond that limit.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

04

Continue with the word bank on page 37.

- 11 **Jun:** We should define eligible cases and how errors are counted before launching, rather than adjust the measures after seeing the result.
- 12 **Sofia:** Exactly. State the ⁶ _____ and measurement plan up front. The numerator, denominator, and case coverage need to be clear so the committee knows what a favorable result would actually mean.
- 13 **Jun:** One slide is titled Routing Analysis. It contains the walkthrough result and the remaining evidence gap, but the title does not say either.
- 14 **Sofia:** Use an ⁷ _____ that communicates the implication accurately. For example, the evidence supports a limited live test. The heading must not imply proven improvement while the detail says otherwise.
- 15 **Jun:** I can move the detailed walkthrough calculations behind the main story, with a reference for anyone who wants to inspect them.
- 16 **Sofia:** The ⁸ _____ is appropriate for that detail. But keep the lack of live results and the quality condition in the main presentation, because they change how the recommendation should be understood.
- 17 **Jun:** If the committee approves the pilot, the minutes should not say that it approved the entire new operating model.
- 18 **Sofia:** Correct. A ⁹ _____ comes later, after the relevant results and review. We should state that distinction in both the request and the closing summary.
- 19 **Jun:** I will reorder the deck around the request, evidence, proposed test, and decision conditions, with the detailed calculations available separately.
- 20 **Sofia:** That is an ¹⁰ _____. It is shorter because the argument is organized, not because important uncertainty has been removed.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 83

1. decision ask | 2. recommendation | 3. storyline | 4. median | 5. guardrail | 6. success criteria | 7. action title | 8. appendix | 9. rollout decision | 10. executive synthesis

State another bounded pilot request

F Say it

A team proposes a three-week trial at two branches with a \$12,000 budget. No live results exist. The committee is asked to authorize the trial only; broader rollout requires another decision.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

two branches / three weeks / \$12,000 / another decision

Presenter: "The proposed duration is ¹ _____."

Chair: "The trial covers ² _____."

Presenter: "The budget request is ³ _____."

Chair: "Broader rollout requires ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 83

1. three weeks | 2. two branches | 3. \$12,000 | 4. another decision

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Check your answers, then read turns 1-10 with a partner using the corrected words.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress words that distinguish facts from conditions or estimates.
3. Complete and check the four-line exchange. Read it twice, switching roles and keeping the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

A second market is a new request, not a free extension

A Read the situation

05

Respond constructively to additional work by distinguishing the agreed scope from the proposed change and explaining options without premature commitments.

Engagement C18 covers a six-week study of Market A for a fixed \$60,000 fee. At the end of week three, client sponsor Helen asks for the same full study of Market B by the original deadline. The current team cannot complete both full studies in the remaining time. Consultant Raj can prepare options: additional resources subject to availability, an extension, a narrower Market B scan, or deferral. Fees and dates for the change are not yet assessed. The signed terms require an agreed written change before extra work begins. Helen has not approved a change.

PEOPLE / Helen: Client sponsor | Raj: Engagement manager

A BOUNDARY IS EASIER TO ACCEPT WITH CHOICES

A blunt refusal can miss an important client need, while an unqualified yes can create an impossible commitment. Acknowledge the purpose of the request, explain the current boundary and capacity, and offer options for an authorized decision. Keep assessment separate from approval.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What does the signed engagement currently cover?

A A completed Market B study

B A six-week study of Market A for \$60,000

C Full studies of both markets for the same fee

D An unlimited number of markets

2. Can the current team finish both full studies by the original deadline?

A Yes, without changing anything.

B Only if the team labels Market B as Market A.

C No, not under the stated capacity.

D Yes, because the request came from the sponsor.

3. What must precede extra work?

A The consultant's unilateral fee decision

B An agreed written change under the signed terms

C An informal assumption of future approval

D A completed invoice after unapproved work

Answers and explanations: [page 84](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

scope baseline

The agreed work boundaries against which changes are assessed.

IN USE protect the scope baseline

statement of work

A document specifying the work, outputs, and relevant engagement terms.

IN USE review the statement of work

fixed fee

A specified charge for a defined scope under the agreement.

IN USE confirm the fixed fee

change request

A proposal to alter agreed work or arrangements.

IN USE raise a change request

scope creep

Uncontrolled growth in work beyond the agreed scope.

IN USE prevent scope creep

impact assessment

Examination of a proposed change's consequences.

IN USE complete an impact assessment

resource capacity

The work a team can perform with its available people and time.

IN USE assess resource capacity

resource availability

Whether suitable people or other resources can be assigned when needed.

IN USE check resource availability

deliverable

A specified output to be supplied.

IN USE define the deliverable

acceptance criterion

A condition used to determine whether an output meets the agreement.

IN USE agree acceptance criteria

change authorization

Formal permission for the specified change.

IN USE obtain change authorization

commercial terms

Agreed conditions concerning fees and other business arrangements.

IN USE confirm commercial terms

Precision check

A fixed fee applies to the defined scope, not automatically to any additional request. The \$60,000 figure is the existing Market A fee. No price or delivery date has yet been established for Market B, and the exercise supplies no basis for inventing one.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

schedule extension

An approved increase in the time allowed.

IN USE propose a schedule extension

scope trade-off

Exchanging one work element for another under agreed conditions.

IN USE explain a scope trade-off

high-level scan

A limited overview rather than a full detailed study.

IN USE offer a high-level scan

depth of analysis

The detail and rigor of examination provided.

IN USE specify the depth of analysis

assumption log

A record of conditions used in planning or analysis.

IN USE update the assumption log

dependency

A condition or task on which another depends.

IN USE identify a dependency

rework

Work needed to revise or repeat previous output.

IN USE estimate rework

change register

A record of requested changes and their status.

IN USE maintain the change register

pending approval

Awaiting the relevant authorized decision.

IN USE mark the change pending approval

deferral

Moving a decision or activity to a later time.

IN USE propose deferral

out-of-scope request

A request beyond the currently agreed work.

IN USE assess an out-of-scope request

written variation

A documented agreed change to specified engagement terms.

IN USE execute a written variation

Precision check

A high-level scan is not the same deliverable as a full market study. Specify coverage, evidence depth, exclusions, and acceptance conditions if that option is developed. Calling a narrower product a full study would conceal the trade-off rather than solve it.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ACKNOWLEDGE THE PURPOSE

"I understand why Market B has become important."

NAME THE ADDITIONAL REQUEST

"A full Market B study is a change to that scope."

OFFER ASSESSMENT

"We can assess options for resources, timing, and analytical depth."

CHECK PEOPLE BEFORE PROMISING

"Additional resources depend on suitable people being available."

STATE THE CURRENT AGREEMENT

"The signed scope covers the six-week Market A study."

DESCRIBE CAPACITY HONESTLY

"The current team cannot complete both full studies by the existing deadline."

AVOID AN EARLY QUOTE

"The revised fee and dates have not yet been assessed."

EXPLAIN AN EXTENSION

"More time is one option, subject to agreement."

Has become important

Acknowledges the new need without accepting the work automatically.

Current team

Makes the capacity statement specific rather than claiming no solution exists.

Have not yet

Identifies an assessment gap, not a refusal to discuss options.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

DISTINGUISH A SMALLER PRODUCT

"A high-level scan would have narrower coverage than a full study."

PRESERVE EXISTING COMMITMENTS

"We should show what each option does to Market A."

KEEP STATUS ACCURATE

"The request is being assessed, not yet approved."

RECORD THE DECISION

"Capture the chosen scope, fee, dates, and responsibilities in the variation."

OFFER DEFERRAL

"We could schedule Market B as a later phase."

STATE THE APPROVAL CONDITION

"The terms require an agreed written change before extra work starts."

DEFINE ACCEPTANCE

"Agree what the revised deliverable must contain."

CLOSE WITHOUT OVERPROMISING

"I will return with assessed choices rather than commit to an unsupported deadline."

Narrower coverage

States the real difference in the smaller deliverable.

Before extra work

Preserves the agreed approval sequence.

Assessed choices

Promises an evaluation process rather than an unknown result.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which response is constructive and accurate?

- A** We will invent a new fee after finishing.
- B** We can assess ways to add Market B, but both full studies do not fit the current capacity and deadline.
- C** Yes, both are included with no changes.
- D** Every new client request must be refused.

2. Which statement about the scan is appropriate?

- A** It is identical to a full study because the title is similar.
- B** It needs no agreed deliverable.
- C** Its limitations should be hidden in the appendix only.
- D** Its reduced coverage and depth must be specified.

3. What is the status of Market B?

- A** Included in the original Market A scope
- B** Requested and awaiting assessment and written agreement
- C** Approved by the mere act of asking
- D** Already delivered

4. What should an impact assessment include?

- A** A guaranteed date before checking capacity
- B** A change in wording with no work consequences
- C** Effects on scope, people, fees, timing, and existing commitments
- D** Only whether the client sounds enthusiastic

Answers and explanations: [page 84](#).

A second market is a new request, not a free extension

E Conversations / turns 1-10

05

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

high-level scan / resource capacity / acceptance criteria / scope baseline / resource availability / scope trade-off / change authorization / commercial terms / change register / impact assessment

- 01 **Helen:** Market B has become urgent. Could you add the same full study and still present both markets at the end of the six weeks?
- 02 **Raj:** I understand the need. Our ¹ _____ covers Market A at the fixed sixty-thousand-dollar fee. A full second study is additional work, so we need to assess how it would fit.
- 03 **Helen:** We are halfway through the engagement. I had hoped the team could reuse enough of the approach to keep the original date.
- 04 **Raj:** Reuse may help, but the current ² _____ does not support both full studies in the remaining time. I do not want to promise a date that depends on work we have not resourced.
- 05 **Helen:** What options can you bring back? I would prefer choices to a simple statement that the request is outside scope.
- 06 **Raj:** We can prepare an ³ _____. The options include additional resources if available, an extension, a narrower scan of Market B, or a later phase. Each has different implications.
- 07 **Helen:** If you add people, can you guarantee that the final date stays unchanged?
- 08 **Raj:** Not before checking ⁴ _____. We need suitable people at the right time, plus any coordination and review capacity. More names on a staffing plan do not automatically remove every dependency.
- 09 **Helen:** We might accept less depth for Market B if it gives us an initial view before the committee meeting.
- 10 **Raj:** Then define a ⁵ _____ explicitly. We should agree the questions, evidence depth, exclusions, and output, rather than describe a smaller product as if it were the full study you originally requested.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 46.

05

- 11 **Helen:** I also need to know whether any of these choices would weaken the work already promised for Market A.
- 12 **Raj:** That is part of the ⁶ _____. We will show what stays unchanged and what would move or reduce. The original commitments should not quietly disappear because the new request feels more urgent.
- 13 **Helen:** Could the team begin researching Market B while procurement and I work through the paperwork?
- 14 **Raj:** The signed terms require ⁷ _____ through an agreed written change before extra work starts. We can assess the request now, but we should not treat pending approval as permission to deliver it.
- 15 **Helen:** Understood. I have requested the change, not approved a revised fee or schedule. Those details still need to come back.
- 16 **Raj:** Correct. The ⁸ _____ and dates for Market B are not established yet. The existing fee is not an estimate for the extra work, and I will not invent one before the assessment.
- 17 **Helen:** If we choose the narrower scan, the document should say how we will judge whether it has met the agreed brief.
- 18 **Raj:** We will include ⁹ _____ for that output. A shared definition of completion helps avoid a later disagreement over whether a preliminary overview was supposed to be a full market study.
- 19 **Helen:** Please bring back the options with their effects on Market A, the timing, and the approval needed for the selected route.
- 20 **Raj:** I will record the request in the ¹⁰ _____ and return with assessed choices. Once the authorized parties agree the written variation, we can plan the added work against the actual approved terms.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 85

1. scope baseline | 2. resource capacity | 3. impact assessment | 4. resource availability | 5. high-level scan | 6. scope trade-off | 7. change authorization | 8. commercial terms | 9. acceptance criteria | 10. change register

State another unapproved scope addition

F Say it

A four-week engagement covers Region East for \$35,000. In week two, the client requests Region West as well. Extra work requires an agreed written variation. Its fee, staffing, and timing have not been assessed.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

Region West / \$35,000 / written variation / Region East

Manager: "The current geographic scope is ¹ _____."

Client: "The additional requested region is ² _____."

Manager: "The existing fee is ³ _____."

Client: "Extra work requires an agreed ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 85

1. Region East | 2. Region West | 3. \$35,000 | 4. written variation

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Check your answers, then read turns 1-10 with a partner using the corrected words.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress words that distinguish facts from conditions or estimates.
3. Complete and check the four-line exchange. Read it twice, switching roles and keeping the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

The recommendation depends on staff the client does not have

A Read the situation

Acknowledge a missed constraint, restate its effect on the recommendation, and agree a credible correction without becoming defensive or promising an untested solution.

06

Consultant Ronan recommends an eight-week pilot requiring two full-time-equivalent staff throughout. Client operations lead Leila points out that only 0.5 full-time equivalent is available during that period, with no additional hiring approved this quarter. Leila had supplied the limit in a discovery email dated 8 September, which the team missed. The proposed workload has not been redesigned. Ronan must own the oversight, correct the assumption, and assess a smaller scope or different timing. He commits to a revised assessment by Wednesday at 15:00 local time, not to a feasible launch by then.

PEOPLE / Leila: Client operations lead | Ronan: Consultant

ACKNOWLEDGE BEFORE EXPLAINING

When feedback identifies a genuine omission, an immediate defense can make the client repeat the problem more forcefully. State what the team missed and its consequence first. Then clarify the constraint and the repair plan without turning the conversation into a search for someone else to blame.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What staffing did the recommendation assume?

A Two full-time equivalents for eight weeks

C Unlimited approved hiring

B Half a full-time equivalent for one day

D A completed capacity assessment

2. What staffing is actually available?

A Two full-time equivalents

C An unknown unlimited pool

B Four additional hires

D 0.5 full-time equivalent during the period

3. What is promised for Wednesday at 15:00?

A Proof that the original recommendation was feasible

C A guaranteed pilot launch

B A revised assessment

D Approved new hiring

Answers and explanations: page 86.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

client feedback

Information from the client about the work or its usefulness.

IN USE respond to client feedback

staffing constraint

A limit on the people or capacity available.

IN USE acknowledge a staffing constraint

FTE

Full-time equivalent; capacity expressed relative to a defined full-time workload.

IN USE calculate available FTE

capacity assumption

A planning belief about resources available for the work.

IN USE correct the capacity assumption

resourcing model

A representation of people, roles, and effort needed.

IN USE revise the resourcing model

workload

The amount of work assigned or required.

IN USE assess the workload

feasibility

Whether an option can be carried out under relevant conditions.

IN USE reassess feasibility

oversight

A missed fact or step; in other contexts, supervisory responsibility.

IN USE acknowledge the oversight

fact check

Verification of a statement against relevant evidence.

IN USE complete a fact check

discovery record

Information captured during the initial client inquiry.

IN USE review the discovery record

assumption register

A documented list of planning assumptions and their status.

IN USE update the assumption register

capacity gap

A difference between required and available resources.

IN USE quantify the capacity gap

Precision check

Two FTE required and 0.5 FTE available create a 1.5-FTE capacity gap. The available amount is one quarter of the assumed capacity. This does not automatically prove the pilot will take four times as long: tasks, sequencing, and minimum staffing may prevent simple scaling.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

critical task

Work essential to the intended result or necessary sequence.

IN USE identify critical tasks

bottleneck

A point limiting the rate or capacity of a process.

IN USE locate the bottleneck

phasing

Dividing work into sequenced stages.

IN USE assess phased delivery

scope reduction

A deliberate decrease in included work.

IN USE evaluate a scope reduction

de-scoping

Removing work from the agreed or proposed scope through the relevant process.

IN USE make de-scoping explicit

schedule constraint

A limit on when work can occur or finish.

IN USE clarify schedule constraints

hiring approval

Authorization to recruit or add the relevant staff.

IN USE confirm hiring approval

client sign-off

The client's relevant formal acceptance or approval.

IN USE obtain client sign-off

revision note

A record of what changed and why.

IN USE include a revision note

corrective action

A step addressing an identified problem or error.

IN USE agree corrective action

accountability

Responsibility for explaining and addressing one's work or decisions.

IN USE demonstrate accountability

follow-through

Completion of agreed next steps.

IN USE maintain follow-through

06

Precision check

An apology does not by itself repair the recommendation. Correct the documented assumption, identify affected tasks and outputs, and assess alternatives with the client. The Wednesday commitment is to provide that assessment; feasibility and authorization remain separate questions.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ACKNOWLEDGE THE MISS

"You supplied the staffing limit, and we missed it."

AVOID A DEFENSIVE QUALIFIER

"That omission is ours to correct."

RESPECT THE HIRING LIMIT

"No additional hiring is approved this quarter."

AVOID SIMPLE SCALING

"We cannot assume a quarter of the staff means a four-times-longer schedule."

STATE THE CONSEQUENCE

"Our recommendation depends on capacity that is not available."

CONFIRM THE CONSTRAINT

"The available capacity is half an FTE for this period."

QUANTIFY THE GAP

"The proposal assumes one and a half FTE more than is available."

REVIEW THE WORK

"We need to identify which tasks and dependencies are affected."

06

We missed it

Owens the documented omission directly.

Depends on

Connects the incorrect assumption to the recommendation.

Not available

Identifies a practical limit, not unwillingness to cooperate.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

OFFER BOUNDED ALTERNATIVES

"We will assess a smaller scope or different timing."

AVOID A PROMISED SOLUTION

"I cannot yet say which option will be feasible."

CORRECT THE RECORD

"We will update the assumption register and mark the previous version as superseded."

SEPARATE REVIEW FROM APPROVAL

"Reviewing an option does not approve its staffing or launch."

KEEP THE GOAL VISIBLE

"Which parts of the pilot are essential to the decision it must support?"

SET THE NEXT COMMITMENT

"I will return with the revised assessment by Wednesday at fifteen hundred local time."

INVITE FACTUAL VERIFICATION

"Please confirm that we have represented the capacity limit correctly."

CLOSE WITH FOLLOW-THROUGH

"The next version will state the constraint, its effects, and the assessed alternatives."

06

Cannot assume

Rejects an unsupported arithmetic shortcut.

Will assess

Commits to work whose result is not yet known.

Superseded

Makes clear which version should no longer guide decisions.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

06

1. Which opening best addresses the feedback?

- A** You supplied the limit, and we missed it; the recommendation needs revision.
- B** You should have repeated the email more often.
- C** The slide looks strong, so the constraint is irrelevant.
- D** We can call two FTE half an FTE to resolve it.

2. What is the capacity gap?

- A** 2.5 FTE
- B** No gap
- C** 1.5 FTE
- D** 0.25 FTE

3. Why is multiplying the duration by four not a proven fix?

- A** The client has already approved a longer schedule.
- B** The two measures use no common workload basis.
- C** Task sequencing and minimum staffing may prevent simple proportional scaling.
- D** Arithmetic never matters in staffing.

4. Which follow-up statement is accurate?

- A** Hiring is approved because a revision is underway.
- B** The original version should remain the sole decision basis.
- C** A revised assessment will be supplied by the agreed time; launch feasibility remains to be established.
- D** The pilot is guaranteed to launch by Wednesday.

Answers and explanations: [page 86](#).

The recommendation depends on staff the client does not have

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

06

WORD + PHRASE BANK

resourcing model / revision note / feasibility / capacity gap / phasing / client sign-off / staffing constraint / capacity assumption / scope reduction / follow-through

- 01 **Leila:** The pilot needs two full-time-equivalent staff for eight weeks. We have only half an FTE available, and I told the team that in the September eighth discovery email.
- 02 **Ronan:** You did, and we missed that ¹ _____. Our recommendation depends on capacity you do not have. That omission is ours to correct, rather than something you should have had to raise again.
- 03 **Leila:** I need the team to understand that no extra hiring is approved this quarter. We cannot simply add people because the presentation assumes them.
- 04 **Ronan:** I will correct the ² _____ explicitly. The current proposal assumes two FTE, while only half an FTE is available during the period. Additional hiring cannot be treated as an agreed solution.
- 05 **Leila:** That is a large difference. I do not want a cosmetic change to the slide while the same workload remains underneath.
- 06 **Ronan:** The ³ _____ is one and a half FTE. We need to examine the work itself, not relabel the resource requirement or imply that the original plan fits.
- 07 **Leila:** Someone suggested making the pilot four times longer because the available capacity is one quarter of what you assumed.
- 08 **Ronan:** That does not establish ⁴ _____. Some tasks may need people together or depend on a particular sequence. We cannot infer a workable schedule solely by multiplying the duration.
- 09 **Leila:** What will you check before bringing another option back? The operation still needs a useful answer, but the people limit is real.
- 10 **Ronan:** We will revisit the ⁵ _____. Identify the essential tasks, dependencies, and review effort, then assess what could be reduced, phased, or moved without disguising the effect on the pilot's purpose.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 55.

- 11 **Leila:** A smaller pilot might be possible, provided it still tests something meaningful and does not leave the committee with an unusable result.
- 12 **Ronan:** Any ⁶ _____ needs a clear consequence statement. We should say which question the smaller test can answer and which part of the original ambition would remain untested.
- 13 **Leila:** There may also be a later period with different capacity, but I cannot promise those people now.
- 14 **Ronan:** We can assess that ⁷ _____ option with its conditions visible. We should not replace one unsupported staffing assumption with another about resources that may become available later.
- 15 **Leila:** When can I expect a revised assessment? Please distinguish that from telling the committee we have an approved launch plan.
- 16 **Ronan:** By Wednesday at fifteen hundred local time, I will provide the assessment and a ⁸ _____. It will state what changed, why it changed, and which feasibility or approval questions remain open.
- 17 **Leila:** I can check whether the next version accurately represents our capacity. That review will not authorize additional staffing.
- 18 **Ronan:** Understood. Your factual review is not automatic ⁹ _____ on a new staffing plan or launch. We will identify the actual approval route for whichever option proves supportable.
- 19 **Leila:** Then please make sure the previous version is no longer circulated as the current recommendation.
- 20 **Ronan:** We will mark it superseded and maintain ¹⁰ _____. The next version will show the real constraint, the consequences for the work, and the assessed alternatives rather than repeat the original unsupported plan.

06

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 87

1. staffing constraint | 2. capacity assumption | 3. capacity gap | 4. feasibility | 5. resourcing model | 6. scope reduction | 7. phasing | 8. revision note | 9. client sign-off | 10. follow-through

Correct another capacity assumption

F Say it

A proposed review requires 1.5 FTE, but the client confirms only 0.5 FTE is available. No extra staffing is approved. The consultant promises a revised assessment on Friday, not a completed review.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

0.5 FTE / 1.0 FTE / revised assessment / 1.5 FTE

Consultant: "The proposal assumed ¹ _____."

Client: "Confirmed available capacity is ² _____."

Consultant: "The resulting capacity gap is ³ _____."

Client: "Friday's commitment is a ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 87

1. 1.5 FTE | 2. 0.5 FTE | 3. 1.0 FTE | 4. revised assessment

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Check your answers, then read turns 1-10 with a partner using the corrected words.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress words that distinguish facts from conditions or estimates.
3. Complete and check the four-line exchange. Read it twice, switching roles and keeping the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Receiving the launch email is not readiness

A Read the situation

Explain implementation readiness using training, observed practice, operational cover, and ownership rather than treating communication as adoption.

A new approval process is scheduled to launch on Monday for 12 managers. All 12 received the announcement; 10 completed the required training, and 4 of those 10 have demonstrated the required tasks in supervised practice. The agreed launch conditions require every participating manager to complete training and demonstrated practice, with operational cover assigned. Eight managers have no verified practice result, two still need training, and cover has not been assigned. Change lead Imani and client process owner David must assess the gaps and seek an authorized revised launch plan, not label unassessed people incompetent.

PEOPLE / Imani: Change lead | David: Client process owner

READINESS IS NOT A CHARACTER JUDGMENT

People may appear resistant when they lack time, practice, access, or support. Ask which prerequisite is missing before attributing motives. A visible gap can guide support and scheduling; it should not become a public ranking of people whose ability has not been assessed.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. How many managers have demonstrated the required tasks?

- | | |
|-----------------|---------------|
| A Twelve | B Ten |
| C Eight | D Four |

2. What remains unknown for eight managers?

- | | |
|---|--|
| A Their demonstrated-practice result | B Whether they received the announcement |
| C Whether every one is incompetent | D Whether all training is complete for all twelve |

3. Which launch requirement is entirely unassigned?

- | | |
|---|--|
| A Operational cover | B The announcement recipient list |
| C The title of the process owner | D The four completed demonstrations |

Answers and explanations: page 88.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

change management

Coordinated work helping an organization move to and sustain a different way of operating.

IN USE plan change management

implementation readiness

Evidence that the required conditions for starting an approach are met.

IN USE assess implementation readiness

go-live

The point when a process or system begins actual operation.

IN USE confirm go-live readiness

adoption

Actual use of the intended way of working.

IN USE measure process adoption

proficiency

Demonstrated ability to perform the relevant tasks to the required level.

IN USE verify proficiency

training completion

Finishing the specified learning activity.

IN USE record training completion

supervised practice

Task rehearsal with an appropriate person observing and supporting it.

IN USE arrange supervised practice

role-based training

Learning tailored to the tasks and responsibilities of a role.

IN USE provide role-based training

job aid

A concise reference supporting task performance.

IN USE supply a job aid

dry run

A rehearsal before actual operation.

IN USE conduct a dry run

practice environment

A setting where tasks can be rehearsed without unintended live effects.

IN USE use a practice environment

protected time

Time explicitly set aside from competing work for a specified activity.

IN USE allocate protected time

Precision check

All 12 received the email, 10 completed training, and 4 demonstrated the tasks. These are different measures, not interchangeable adoption rates. Eight have no verified practice result; that is a readiness evidence gap, not evidence that eight people failed an assessment.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

operational cover

Arrangements maintaining normal work while people undertake another task.

IN USE assign operational cover

backfill

Replacement capacity for work someone cannot perform during an assignment or absence.

IN USE arrange backfill

process owner

The person accountable for a defined process and its ongoing management.

IN USE confirm the process owner

change champion

A person helping colleagues understand and adopt an agreed change.

IN USE support change champions

readiness gate

A decision point requiring specified launch conditions to be checked.

IN USE apply the readiness gate

support model

Arrangements for helping users and resolving problems.

IN USE define the support model

hypercare

A defined period of increased support after launch.

IN USE plan hypercare

stabilization

Work to bring a new operation into a reliable ongoing state.

IN USE monitor stabilization

reinforcement

Follow-up support that helps maintain a desired practice.

IN USE provide reinforcement

usage measure

An indicator of whether and how an approach is being used.

IN USE define usage measures

benefit realization

Achievement of intended value after a change, under defined measures.

IN USE track benefit realization

business-as-usual

Normal ongoing operations outside a temporary change effort.

IN USE maintain business-as-usual service

Precision check

Training and demonstrated practice are required for each participating manager, and cover is also required. A smaller launch might be assessable, but it is not automatically authorized. Its scope, support, cover, and approval must be explicit before the original plan is replaced.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

SEPARATE COMMUNICATION FROM READINESS

"Everyone received the announcement, but the launch conditions are not met."

STATE THE PRACTICE POSITION

"Four have demonstrated the required tasks."

NAME THE REMAINING TRAINING

"Two managers still need the required training."

ASK ABOUT SUPPORT

"What protected time and practice support do the remaining managers need?"

STATE THE TRAINING POSITION

"Ten of the twelve managers completed training."

DESCRIBE MISSING EVIDENCE FAIRLY

"Eight have no verified practice result; that does not mean eight failed."

IDENTIFY THE CAPACITY CONDITION

"Operational cover has not yet been assigned."

KEEP THE GATE EXPLICIT

"Each participant must meet the agreed training and practice conditions."

Different measures

Keeps communication, learning, performance, and use distinct.

No verified result

Describes missing evidence without inventing failure.

Still need

Identifies a practical next step rather than a personal deficiency.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

AVOID A BLAME LABEL

"We should not call a missing assessment resistance."

ASSIGN OWNERSHIP

"The process owner needs to confirm the operational arrangements."

MEASURE ACTUAL USE

"Track the intended workflow after launch, not just attendance at training."

REINFORCE THE CHANGE

"Review early issues and provide targeted follow-up support."

DEFINE A SMALLER LAUNCH

"A staged start would need its own approved scope and cover."

PREPARE ASSISTANCE

"Name the support contact and escalation route before go-live."

KEEP BENEFITS SEPARATE

"Process use does not by itself prove that the expected benefit has occurred."

CLOSE THE READINESS REVIEW

"Present the gaps, owners, support needs, and revised decision to the authorized approver."

Each participant

Applies the agreed condition to the relevant launch population.

Would need

Makes a staged launch conditional on its own arrangements.

After launch

Locates actual-use measurement in operation, not before it starts.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which readiness statement is accurate?

- A** Training completion proves sustained adoption.
- B** Four have demonstrated the tasks; eight lack verified practice results.
- C** All twelve are ready because the email arrived.
- D** Eight have failed an assessment.

2. Which next step addresses the stated gaps?

- A** Arrange remaining training, supervised practice, and operational cover before seeking the launch decision.
- B** Send the same email and declare the conditions met.
- C** Remove the agreed gate without authorization.
- D** Assume normal duties will cover themselves.

3. What does a usage measure show?

- A** Necessarily all intended business benefits
- B** Only receipt of the announcement
- C** Automatic approval for every expansion
- D** Actual use of the defined workflow

4. How should a staged launch be described?

- A** A way to hide the eight missing results
- B** A guarantee that every service remains unaffected
- C** A possible revised plan requiring explicit scope, support, cover, and authorization
- D** Already approved because four people demonstrated tasks

Answers and explanations: [page 88](#).

Receiving the launch email is not readiness

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

benefit realization / support model / process owner / adoption / protected time / operational cover / Training completion / implementation readiness / readiness gate / supervised practice

- 01 **David:** The announcement went to all twelve managers, so the project dashboard marks us ready for Monday. I am not convinced that tells the whole story.
- 02 **Imani:** It measures communication, not ¹ _____. Ten managers completed training, four demonstrated the required tasks, and operational cover is still unassigned. Those are separate conditions, not details the email resolves.
- 03 **David:** The four who demonstrated the tasks are among the ten trained managers. The other eight do not have a verified practice result.
- 04 **Imani:** Then say exactly that about ² _____. We should not describe eight people as having failed when they have not supplied a verified result. Missing evidence and demonstrated inability are different.
- 05 **David:** Two managers still need the training itself. Their teams have been busy, and they have not had time set aside.
- 06 **Imani:** They need ³ _____ and an agreed route to complete the requirement. Calling them resistant would not address the scheduling barrier or tell us whether they can perform the tasks.
- 07 **David:** Even trained managers need an opportunity to practice. We should not assume that attendance establishes independent performance.
- 08 **Imani:** Correct. ⁴ _____ is one condition. The agreed launch gate also requires demonstrated practice for each participating manager, plus cover for their normal responsibilities.
- 09 **David:** The cover issue worries me. If everyone practices at the same time, the existing approval queue still needs to be handled.
- 10 **Imani:** We need ⁵ _____ rather than hope the queue manages itself. Assign the people and timing explicitly, and check the consequences for ongoing service before confirming a launch arrangement.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 64.

- 11 **David:** Could the four who have completed both steps begin first while the others finish their preparation?
- 12 **Imani:** A staged start can be assessed at the ⁶ _____. It is not automatically approved. We would need a defined scope, cover, support, and the relevant authorization for that revised plan.
- 13 **David:** I will coordinate those operational arrangements. The change team can support the transition, but somebody in the business must own the process afterward.
- 14 **Imani:** That is the ⁷ _____ role. The handover should state who handles exceptions, maintains the instructions, and decides when an issue needs escalation after the project team steps back.
- 15 **David:** We also need a clear route for questions during the first days. People should not have to find the consultant who last answered an email.
- 16 **Imani:** Define the ⁸ _____ before go-live. A job aid, named contact, and clear escalation route can make assistance predictable, but they do not replace the required practice or operational cover.
- 17 **David:** Once the process starts, we should check whether managers use the intended workflow, rather than keep reporting training attendance as success.
- 18 **Imani:** Yes, measure ⁹ _____ in operation. Use the agreed workflow measures and investigate barriers fairly, without assuming every exception means someone is unwilling to change.
- 19 **David:** And if usage improves, we still need to examine whether the change produces the expected service improvement.
- 20 **Imani:** That is ¹⁰ _____. Keep those measures separate. For now, present the readiness gaps, owners, support needs, and proposed revision to the authorized approver instead of leaving Monday marked ready.

07

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 89

1. implementation readiness | 2. supervised practice | 3. protected time | 4. Training completion | 5. operational cover | 6. readiness gate | 7. process owner | 8. support model | 9. adoption | 10. benefit realization

Separate another set of readiness measures

F Say it

Eight supervisors receive a process notice. Six complete training, and three of those six demonstrate the required tasks. Five have no verified practice result. A start still requires assigned cover and approval.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

three supervisors / no verified practice result / eight supervisors / six supervisors

Lead: "The notice reached ¹ _____."

Owner: "Training is complete for ² _____."

Lead: "Verified task demonstrations total ³ _____."

Owner: "The five others have ⁴ _____, not necessarily failed."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 89

1. eight supervisors | 2. six supervisors | 3. three supervisors | 4. no verified practice result

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Check your answers, then read turns 1-10 with a partner using the corrected words.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress words that distinguish facts from conditions or estimates.
3. Complete and check the four-line exchange. Read it twice, switching roles and keeping the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Agreement on the problem is not approval of an option

A Read the situation

Close a divided decision meeting by summarizing trade-offs, distinguishing agreement from authorization, and recording the actual decision and owned follow-ups.

A steering committee agrees that service handoffs need improvement but is split between two proposals. Option A is estimated at six weeks and \$80,000, with manual reporting and staffing still to be confirmed. Option B is estimated at twelve weeks and \$140,000, with automated reporting dependent on an unverified system integration. With two minutes left, chair Marta defers the choice to Friday at 10:00 local time. Consultant Ethan will verify the integration position by Thursday at 12:00; operations lead Nora will confirm Option A staffing by the same time. Neither option nor additional implementation spending is approved.

PEOPLE / Marta: Steering committee chair | Ethan: Consultant presenting the readout

08

AN ACCURATE CLOSE CAN PRESERVE A DIFFICULT DISCUSSION

A presenter may want to leave a meeting with apparent agreement, especially after extensive work. Do not turn shared concern into a fictional approval. State the unresolved trade-off, the authorized next step, and the decision date so the discussion can advance without rewriting what happened.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What does the committee agree on?

A Approval of Option A

C Authorization of both budgets

B Approval of Option B

D The need to improve service handoffs

2. What did Marta decide at the close?

A Authorize the consultant to choose privately

C Approve automatic rollout that afternoon

B Defer the option choice to Friday at 10:00 local time

D Remove every unresolved dependency

3. What must Ethan verify by Thursday at 12:00?

A Staffing for Option A on Nora's behalf

C A guaranteed \$60,000 saving

B A completed twelve-week implementation

D The system integration position for Option B

Answers and explanations: page 90.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

steering committee

A governance group overseeing direction and specified decisions.

IN USE brief the steering committee

readout

A presentation of findings, status, or decisions.

IN USE deliver the final readout

decision log

A record of choices, authority, conditions, and dates.

IN USE maintain the decision log

minutes

The formal record of a meeting's relevant discussion and decisions.

IN USE confirm the minutes

consensus

Shared agreement, whose scope should be stated.

IN USE establish the scope of consensus

dissent

A stated disagreement with a proposed view or choice.

IN USE record material dissent

deferred decision

A choice moved to a later specified point.

IN USE document a deferred decision

conditional approval

Authorization that depends on stated conditions.

IN USE distinguish conditional approval

endorsement

An expression of support that may differ from formal authorization.

IN USE clarify the endorsement

decision authority

The role or body permitted to make the relevant choice.

IN USE confirm decision authority

option appraisal

A structured comparison of alternatives.

IN USE complete the option appraisal

trade-off

A balance between competing benefits, costs, or conditions.

IN USE explain the trade-off

08

Precision check

Option B is estimated to cost \$60,000 more and take six weeks longer than Option A. Those differences do not establish that either is preferable. Reporting capability, staffing, integration, and the relative importance of the criteria remain material to the decision.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

implementation estimate

A projection of time or resources needed to execute an option.

IN USE qualify the implementation estimate

integration dependency

A reliance on connecting systems or processes successfully.

IN USE verify the integration dependency

manual reporting

Reporting that requires human preparation rather than the proposed automation.

IN USE account for manual reporting

automated reporting

Reporting produced through defined automated processes.

IN USE assess automated reporting

decision criterion

A factor used to compare and choose between options.

IN USE prioritize decision criteria

open item

A question or action not yet resolved.

IN USE track open items

action owner

The person responsible for a defined next step.

IN USE name the action owner

due time

The specified time by which a follow-up is required.

IN USE confirm the due time

decision pack

The material supplied to support a forthcoming choice.

IN USE update the decision pack

approval status

Whether and on what terms a proposal has been authorized.

IN USE state the approval status

record correction

An amendment making a decision record accurate.

IN USE request a record correction

handover

Transfer of relevant responsibility and information.

IN USE complete the decision handover

Precision check

Deferral is not conditional approval. Here the committee has authorized neither option nor extra implementation spending. A record saying approved subject to checks would misrepresent the meeting, even though named people have been assigned to resolve the open questions.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

STATE THE SHARED GROUND

"We agree that the handoff problem needs to be addressed."

COMPARE THE ESTIMATES

"Option B is estimated at sixty thousand dollars more and six weeks longer."

KEEP THE DEPENDENCY VISIBLE

"The integration required for Option B has not been verified."

RESPECT THE CLOSE

"The chair has deferred the choice to Friday at ten hundred local time."

NAME THE UNRESOLVED CHOICE

"We have not agreed which option to implement."

STATE THE CAPABILITY DIFFERENCE

"Option A uses manual reporting; Option B proposes automated reporting."

KEEP STAFFING PROVISIONAL

"Option A staffing still needs confirmation."

AVOID FICTIONAL APPROVAL

"This is a deferred decision, not an approval subject to checks."

08

Shared ground

Separates the agreed problem from the unresolved remedy.

Estimated

Preserves the projected status of cost and schedule figures.

Has not been verified

Keeps a material dependency visible.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

ASSIGN THE TECHNICAL FOLLOW-UP

"Ethan will verify the integration position by Thursday at noon."

KEEP SPENDING STATUS CLEAR

"No additional implementation spending has been approved."

PREPARE THE NEXT DISCUSSION

"Update the option comparison with the two follow-up results."

READ BACK THE RECORD

"May I confirm the decision, owners, due times, and approval status?"

ASSIGN THE OPERATIONAL FOLLOW-UP

"Nora will confirm Option A staffing by the same deadline."

PRESERVE DISAGREEMENT

"Record the material trade-offs without claiming unanimous support for an option."

CLARIFY AUTHORITY

"The committee will make the option decision at the agreed meeting."

CLOSE ACCURATELY

"The problem is agreed, the option is deferred, and the next steps are assigned."

08

Deferred, not approved

Distinguishes two different governance outcomes.

By the same deadline

Aligns follow-ups without merging their owners.

Read back

Gives the chair a chance to correct the record before circulation.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which minute accurately records the meeting?

- A Both options were approved because the problem was agreed.
- B Option B was approved subject to integration checks.
- C The consultant may choose whichever option is easier.
- D The option decision is deferred to Friday at 10:00; neither option nor additional spending is approved.

2. What is Option B's estimated cost premium over A?

- A \$20,000
- B No difference
- C \$60,000
- D \$140,000

3. Who owns Option A staffing confirmation?

- A Nora
- B Ethan
- C Every committee member equally, with no named owner
- D The system integration vendor by default

4. Which closing behavior is most useful?

- A Describe silence as unanimous option approval.
- B Remove dissent from the record to make it simpler.
- C Present estimated timing as a guaranteed delivery date.
- D Read back the unresolved choice, follow-up owners, deadlines, and approval status.

Answers and explanations: page 90.

Agreement on the problem is not approval of an option

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

open item / action owner / option appraisal / decision log / dissent / deferred decision / integration dependency / consensus / trade-off / approval status

08

- 01 **Marta:** We have two minutes left. Everyone agrees that the service handoffs need improvement, but we are still divided over which option to implement.
- 02 **Ethan:** Then the scope of ¹ _____ is the problem, not the solution. I will summarize the trade-off without presenting shared concern as approval of either proposal.
- 03 **Marta:** Please keep the cost, timing, and reporting differences clear. The committee has heard many details and needs the comparison in one place.
- 04 **Ethan:** The ² _____ shows A at an estimated six weeks and eighty thousand dollars with manual reporting. B is estimated at twelve weeks and one hundred forty thousand with automated reporting.
- 05 **Marta:** So B is estimated to cost sixty thousand more and take six weeks longer. Its automation is not yet a confirmed capability.
- 06 **Ethan:** Correct. The ³ _____ remains unverified. We should not describe B as ready simply because automated reporting appears in the proposed design.
- 07 **Marta:** Option A is not fully ready either. Nora still needs to confirm that the required staff can be assigned.
- 08 **Ethan:** That ⁴ _____ stays visible in the comparison. The shorter estimate does not establish that the people are available, just as B's design does not establish a working integration.
- 09 **Marta:** We do not have enough resolved information to choose now. I am deferring the option decision to Friday at ten hundred local time.
- 10 **Ethan:** I will record a ⁵ _____. Neither option is approved today, and no additional implementation spending is authorized. That is different from approving one option subject to a final check.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 73.

- 11 **Marta:** Exactly. I do not want the minutes to say approved subject to confirmation. We have not selected an option.
- 12 **Ethan:** I will make the ⁶ _____ explicit. Assigning evidence-gathering actions does not change the status of the implementation proposals or permit anyone to begin the added work.
- 13 **Marta:** Ethan, please verify the integration position by Thursday at noon. Nora will confirm Option A staffing by the same time.
- 14 **Ethan:** I will list each ⁷ _____ separately. My follow-up is the integration position; Nora's is staffing. Both are due Thursday at twelve hundred local time for the updated decision material.
- 15 **Marta:** The next discussion should make clear what we gain and give up with each option, not just list two prices.
- 16 **Ethan:** We will preserve the ⁸ _____. The comparison should connect the cost and timing estimates to reporting capability, staffing, and integration, with any remaining uncertainty stated rather than hidden.
- 17 **Marta:** Some members favor speed, while others value automation more. Record that disagreement without presenting it as personal resistance.
- 18 **Ethan:** The relevant ⁹ _____ concerns priorities and evidence. We can summarize those differences accurately without claiming unanimity or attributing motives that members did not state.
- 19 **Marta:** Read back the close now, so we can correct anything before the record circulates.
- 20 **Ethan:** The ¹⁰ _____ will show the agreed problem, the deferred option choice for Friday at ten, and the Thursday-noon integration and staffing follow-ups. Neither option nor extra implementation spending is approved.

08

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 91

1. consensus | 2. option appraisal | 3. integration dependency | 4. open item | 5. deferred decision | 6. approval status | 7. action owner | 8. trade-off | 9. dissent | 10. decision log

Record another deferred choice accurately

F Say it

A committee agrees on a problem but defers the option choice to Tuesday at 09:00. Mei must confirm staffing by Monday at 13:00. No option or additional spending is approved.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

Mei / not approved / Tuesday at 09:00 / deferred

Chair: "The option choice is ¹ _____."

Presenter: "The next decision time is ² _____."

Chair: "The staffing action owner is ³ _____."

Presenter: "Additional spending is ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 91

1. deferred | 2. Tuesday at 09:00 | 3. Mei | 4. not approved

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Check your answers, then read turns 1-10 with a partner using the corrected words.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Stress words that distinguish facts from conditions or estimates.
3. Complete and check the four-line exchange. Read it twice, switching roles and keeping the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

01 Briefing and language checks

Client Discovery and Problem Definition

A Briefing checks / page 4

1. What must the executive committee decide?

A. Whether to centralize the two centers or retain them separately

The stated choice is centralization versus separate operation; no closure or staffing decision has been approved.

2. When is the decision needed?

A. By 30 November

The brief gives 30 November as the executive committee's decision deadline.

3. Which criteria belong in the comparison?

A. Cost, response time, and service continuity, including transition effects

The sponsor explicitly requires three criteria and transition effects, not a cost-only benchmark.

D Language checks / page 9

1. Which problem statement fits the brief?

C. Should North and South be centralized, given cost, response time, continuity, and transition effects?

The appropriate question preserves the actual alternatives and criteria without presuming an approval or result.

2. Which benchmark caveat matters?

B. Peer service scope and cost definitions may differ.

A useful peer comparison requires comparable boundaries and measures, not merely familiar organization names.

3. What does the evidence gap mean?

B. Staffing and customer-impact information is still needed.

The gap identifies information required for the comparison without deciding the eventual recommendation.

4. Which phrase preserves engagement authority?

A. This phase evaluates options; implementation requires a separate authorized decision.

An analytical engagement supports the client's decision but does not itself authorize implementation.

01 Conversation answers

Client Discovery and Problem Definition

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 10-11

- 1. peer group.** Turn 2. The comparison organizations should fit the decision and relevant service characteristics, not merely be familiar names.
- 2. decision question.** Turn 4. The actual choice is centralization versus separate operation; benchmarking supports that decision rather than replacing it.
- 3. decision deadline.** Turn 6. The committee needs the recommendation by 30 November, which guides evidence collection and review timing.
- 4. decision criteria.** Turn 8. Cost, response time, and continuity are the agreed comparison factors, including effects during transition.
- 5. transition cost.** Turn 10. These costs arise during the change and must remain distinct from settled operating costs.
- 6. comparability.** Turn 12. Different hours, case types, or cost definitions can distort an apparently simple peer comparison.
- 7. baseline.** Turn 14. The baseline describes current operations; missing staffing and customer information must remain explicit.
- 8. in-scope.** Turn 16. The agreed analysis includes transition implications but does not automatically include a full implementation plan.
- 9. decision owner.** Turn 18. The executive committee makes the choice; the sponsor coordinates without independently authorizing closure.
- 10. engagement charter.** Turn 20. The charter records the shared purpose, boundaries, roles, and timing before detailed analysis begins.

F Transfer conversation

Page 12

1. a new competition

Consultant: "The actual alternatives are renewal or a new competition."

The price comparison supports this stated choice, not an already approved provider change.

2. procurement committee

Sponsor: "The decision owner is the procurement committee."

The committee holds the stated decision role, while the sponsor supplies engagement direction.

3. 15 January

Consultant: "The decision deadline is 15 January."

This date determines when the comparison must support the authorized choice.

4. transition risk

Sponsor: "The comparison must include total cost, performance, and transition risk."

Transition risk is an explicit criterion alongside cost and service performance.

02 Briefing and language checks

Hypotheses and Issue Trees

A Briefing checks / page 13

1. How many departing accounts were interviewed?

B. Twenty of the sixty departing accounts

Twenty customers volunteered for interviews, while sixty accounts departed in total.

2. Why do the mentions add to more than twenty?

A. Respondents could mention multiple issues.

Multiple responses permit overlapping categories, so the mention counts need not sum to the number interviewed.

3. What has the team established about causation?

B. No causal driver has been isolated.

The brief explicitly leaves causal drivers unresolved despite the frequency of particular interview mentions.

D Language checks / page 18

1. Which finding is supported?

C. Twelve of twenty volunteer interviewees mentioned price.

The supported statement retains the sample and what respondents said without converting mentions into causal proof.

2. Which follow-up best tests rather than protects the hypothesis?

D. Examine whether comparable accounts with similar price changes stayed.

Comparable retained accounts may challenge the proposed explanation, although comparison quality and confounders still need examination.

3. How should the issue categories be presented?

C. As overlapping mentions, with the coding method explained

The multi-response design requires clear overlap disclosure to avoid misleading totals.

4. What makes an analytical priority useful?

C. It could change the decision and has an explicit evidence test.

Priority should follow decision relevance and a testable inquiry, not convenience or guaranteed agreement.

02 Conversation answers

Hypotheses and Issue Trees

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 19-20

1. hypothesis. Turn 2. Price is an explanation to test, not a cause established by interview frequency.

2. overlap. Turn 4. Several topics can describe the same respondent, so their counts can exceed the interview count.

3. sample. Turn 6. The twenty interviewees are not automatically representative of all sixty departures, and mentions do not establish cause.

4. issue tree. Turn 8. The tree organizes decision-relevant subquestions without treating its initial branches as proven explanations.

5. MECE. Turn 10. MECE checks structure; the label does not make interacting customer experiences independent or exclusive.

6. causal mechanism. Turn 12. This asks how and when price could influence departure, beyond merely recording a repeated complaint.

7. disconfirming evidence. Turn 14. Comparable retained accounts could weaken the price explanation; comparison quality still needs examination.

8. segmentation. Turn 16. Defined customer groups can reveal different patterns that a combined result might conceal.

9. triangulation. Turn 18. Comparing evidence sources can inform the explanation without automatically establishing a causal effect.

10. analytical priority. Turn 20. A priority is a decision-relevant test with an evidence source and owner, not merely an easy task.

F Transfer conversation

Page 21

1. ten customers

Analyst: "The interview sample contains ten customers."

Ten departing customers were interviewed, not the full population of forty departures.

2. 60%

Manager: "Onboarding was mentioned by 60% of interviewees."

Six divided by ten equals sixty percent within this interview sample.

3. overlapping mentions

Analyst: "The categories contain overlapping mentions."

Multiple answers were allowed, so onboarding and support may describe the same people.

4. causal driver

Manager: "The result does not establish a causal driver."

Topic frequency alone neither isolates the cause nor represents all departing customers.

03 Briefing and language checks

Data Requests and Client Burden

A Briefing checks / page 22

1. How many items are required for the first analysis?

C. Six

The brief identifies six measures needed first and leaves the remaining thirty-four unprioritized.

2. Which period is required?

D. January through June, monthly, for both centers

The required structure is monthly coverage from January through June for North and South.

3. What is the timing problem?

D. A Friday deadline is later than the Wednesday workshop that needs the analysis.

The first analysis must support Wednesday, so its necessary inputs need a feasible earlier arrangement.

D Language checks / page 27

1. Which revised request is most useful?

C. Six defined monthly measures first, with agreed owners and dates; prioritize the rest separately.

A staged request aligns the immediate analysis with defined information, accountable owners, and feasible delivery.

2. What should happen if an existing report is available?

C. Check its definitions, scope, and coverage before accepting it.

Existing reports may reduce effort, but their fields and boundaries must fit the required analysis.

3. What if a priority item cannot arrive before the workshop?

C. Agree a realistic plan and state the resulting analytical limit.

A missing input changes what the analysis can support and should be disclosed rather than concealed.

4. Which information-handling choice fits the first task?

B. Use suitable aggregates through approved access and transfer arrangements.

The case calls for the necessary level of detail and authorized handling, not unrestricted collection or access.

03 Conversation answers

Data Requests and Client Burden

03

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 28-29

- 1. data request list.** Turn 2. The list needs to distinguish the six immediate inputs from later, unprioritized work.
- 2. delivery sequence.** Turn 4. The sequence puts workshop inputs first, with dates negotiated against actual client capacity.
- 3. minimum viable dataset.** Turn 6. The six specified measures supply the initial analysis, rather than every possible future question.
- 4. data dictionary.** Turn 8. Definitions prevent different site meanings from being treated as equivalent simply because labels match.
- 5. granularity.** Turn 10. Suitable monthly center totals may answer the initial question without requiring individual case records.
- 6. reconciliation.** Turn 12. The differing cost allocations need examination so unlike operating boundaries are not silently compared.
- 7. data owner.** Turn 14. The owner confirms and supplies the information, supporting a realistic commitment and accurate definitions.
- 8. secure transfer.** Turn 16. Files need the approved route and permissions, not any convenient communication channel.
- 9. exception log.** Turn 18. The log records missing periods and unresolved definitions rather than silently replacing them.
- 10. version identifier.** Turn 20. The identifier distinguishes supplied files from revisions, making the analysis and corrections traceable.

F Transfer conversation

Page 30

1. four inputs

Consultant: "The first batch contains four inputs."

Four specified inputs support the immediate review, not all twenty-five requested items.

2. Monday

Client: "The first review is on Monday."

Monday is the stated review date that the first delivery sequence must support.

3. twenty-one items

Consultant: "The later group contains twenty-one items."

Subtracting four priority inputs from twenty-five leaves twenty-one items for later prioritization.

4. definitions

Client: "Before using existing summaries, confirm their definitions."

Available files must match the intended measures; their existence alone does not establish suitability.

04 Briefing and language checks

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

04

A Briefing checks / page 31

1. What authorization is requested?

A. A four-week, one-center pilot with a \$20,000 budget

The proposal specifies a bounded pilot and budget, not organization-wide implementation.

2. What evidence exists so far?

D. Walkthroughs suggesting a possible benefit, with no live operating result

The brief identifies walkthrough evidence and explicitly states that live operating results are absent.

3. What are the proposed success measures?

C. Median handling time at most 10 minutes and error rate at most 2%

The proposed test combines the stated median-time threshold with an error-rate guardrail under agreed definitions.

D Language checks / page 36

1. Which opening is decision-focused and accurate?

C. Approve a four-week, one-center pilot for \$20,000 to test the proposed process.

The accurate opening states the bounded authorization being sought without inventing achieved results.

2. Which statement belongs in the main presentation?

B. No live operating result is available yet.

The absence of live evidence materially affects the decision and should not be buried in supporting material.

3. Which comparison preserves the metric?

B. Current median 12 minutes; proposed pilot threshold at most 10 minutes

The comparison keeps the stated summary measure and distinguishes current performance from a proposed threshold.

4. What prevents speed from becoming the only success measure?

B. Report the defined error-rate guardrail alongside handling time.

The proposed pilot requires both speed and quality measures over the agreed eligible-case population.

04 Conversation answers

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 37-38

- 1. decision ask.** Turn 2. The audience needs the specific pilot scope and budget request before the supporting charts.
- 2. recommendation.** Turn 4. The recommendation proposes a test; walkthroughs do not support a promise of live improvement.
- 3. storyline.** Turn 6. The storyline connects the request, evidence, uncertainty, and test rather than merely arranging charts by topic.
- 4. median.** Turn 8. The stated median must not be relabeled as the mean or a value applying to every case.
- 5. guardrail.** Turn 10. The error limit stays visible alongside speed, preventing a one-sided definition of pilot success.
- 6. success criteria.** Turn 12. The thresholds need agreed measurement rules and eligible-case coverage before results are observed.
- 7. action title.** Turn 14. The heading states the supported implication without claiming more than the exhibit establishes.
- 8. appendix.** Turn 16. Supporting calculations can move here; decision-changing evidence limits must remain in the main presentation.
- 9. rollout decision.** Turn 18. Wider implementation needs a separate later authorization; pilot approval does not automatically permit it.
- 10. executive synthesis.** Turn 20. Synthesis connects findings to a bounded decision instead of giving every analysis equal emphasis.

F Transfer conversation

Page 39

1. three weeks

Presenter: "The proposed duration is three weeks."

Three weeks defines the requested trial period, not a permanent implementation.

2. two branches

Chair: "The trial covers two branches."

The specified two-branch boundary limits the scope of the requested authorization.

3. \$12,000

Presenter: "The budget request is \$12,000."

Twelve thousand dollars is the amount supplied for this limited trial.

4. another decision

Chair: "Broader rollout requires another decision."

Trial approval does not automatically authorize expansion beyond the stated scope.

04

05 Briefing and language checks

Scope Management and Change Requests

A Briefing checks / page 40

1. What does the signed engagement currently cover?

B. A six-week study of Market A for \$60,000

Market A is the agreed scope; Market B is an additional request not covered by an approved change.

2. Can the current team finish both full studies by the original deadline?

C. No, not under the stated capacity.

The brief explicitly states that the current team cannot complete both full studies in the remaining time.

3. What must precede extra work?

B. An agreed written change under the signed terms

The fictional contract requires the written change to be agreed before extra work starts.

D Language checks / page 45

1. Which response is constructive and accurate?

B. We can assess ways to add Market B, but both full studies do not fit the current capacity and deadline.

The response acknowledges the need while making the known capacity limit and assessment step explicit.

2. Which statement about the scan is appropriate?

D. Its reduced coverage and depth must be specified.

A smaller product is a meaningful option only when its boundaries and expected output are clear.

3. What is the status of Market B?

B. Requested and awaiting assessment and written agreement

No assessment or agreed written variation exists, so the request remains unapproved additional work.

4. What should an impact assessment include?

C. Effects on scope, people, fees, timing, and existing commitments

A decision requires the practical and commercial consequences, including what happens to the original engagement.

05 Conversation answers

Scope Management and Change Requests

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 46-47

1. scope baseline. Turn 2. The baseline covers Market A; adding Market B changes the agreed work boundaries.

2. resource capacity. Turn 4. The current team cannot complete both full studies by the original deadline, despite possible method reuse.

3. impact assessment. Turn 6. The assessment compares effects on people, time, fees, scope, and the original commitments.

4. resource availability. Turn 8. Suitable extra staff must be verified before they can support a promised deadline.

5. high-level scan. Turn 10. The scan is a narrower product with different coverage and evidence depth from a full study.

6. scope trade-off. Turn 12. Any reduction or exchange in the original work must be explicit, not silently absorbed.

7. change authorization. Turn 14. The agreement requires a written approved change before the additional work starts.

8. commercial terms. Turn 16. The new fee remains unassessed; the existing \$60,000 is not a Market B quotation.

9. acceptance criteria. Turn 18. These define what the revised output must contain so its narrower scope can be reviewed fairly.

10. change register. Turn 20. The register tracks the request's status, distinguishing assessed options from an agreed written variation.

F Transfer conversation

Page 48

1. Region East

Manager: "The current geographic scope is Region East."

Region East alone is included in the existing engagement.

2. Region West

Client: "The additional requested region is Region West."

Region West is new work rather than part of the stated original scope.

3. \$35,000

Manager: "The existing fee is \$35,000."

This amount applies to the original engagement, not an invented quote for the addition.

4. written variation

Client: "Extra work requires an agreed written variation."

The supplied terms make written agreement a prerequisite to starting the additional work.

05

06 Briefing and language checks

Difficult Client Feedback

A Briefing checks / page 49

1. What staffing did the recommendation assume?

A. Two full-time equivalents for eight weeks

The proposed pilot explicitly requires two full-time-equivalent staff throughout the eight-week period.

2. What staffing is actually available?

D. 0.5 full-time equivalent during the period

Leila states the available capacity and the absence of approved additional hiring this quarter.

3. What is promised for Wednesday at 15:00?

B. A revised assessment

Ronan commits to returning with an assessment, not to solving or authorizing the launch by that time.

D Language checks / page 54

1. Which opening best addresses the feedback?

A. You supplied the limit, and we missed it; the recommendation needs revision.

The appropriate response owns the documented omission and connects it to the need for substantive correction.

2. What is the capacity gap?

C. 1.5 FTE

Two required FTE minus half an available FTE leaves a gap of one and a half FTE.

3. Why is multiplying the duration by four not a proven fix?

C. Task sequencing and minimum staffing may prevent simple proportional scaling.

Capacity ratios describe the gap but do not establish how the actual work can be rescheduled.

4. Which follow-up statement is accurate?

C. A revised assessment will be supplied by the agreed time; launch feasibility remains to be established.

The promised deliverable is the revised assessment, not an untested solution or a separate approval.

06 Conversation answers

Difficult Client Feedback

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 55-56

1. staffing constraint. Turn 2. The half-FTE limit was already supplied; the consultant missed it during discovery.

2. capacity assumption. Turn 4. The plan must reflect half an available FTE and the absence of approved additional hiring.

3. capacity gap. Turn 6. Two required FTE minus half available leaves 1.5 FTE; changing slide wording does not remove it.

4. feasibility. Turn 8. Actual tasks and constraints need examination; a capacity ratio alone does not prove a workable schedule.

5. resourcing model. Turn 10. This maps people and effort by task so the proposal can be rebuilt around real capacity.

6. scope reduction. Turn 12. Removing work changes what the pilot can answer, and that consequence must be explicit.

7. phasing. Turn 14. Later stages require confirmed resources; possible future availability is not a staffing commitment.

8. revision note. Turn 16. The note explains the corrected assumption and changes; Wednesday's promise is an assessment, not launch.

9. client sign-off. Turn 18. Checking factual accuracy is not the same as approving staffing or implementation.

10. follow-through. Turn 20. The repair requires completing the promised revision and version correction, not merely apologizing.

F Transfer conversation

Page 57

1. 1.5 FTE

Consultant: "The proposal assumed 1.5 FTE."

One and a half full-time equivalents is the stated requirement in the proposal.

2. 0.5 FTE

Client: "Confirmed available capacity is 0.5 FTE."

Half a full-time equivalent is available, with no extra staffing approved.

3. 1.0 FTE

Consultant: "The resulting capacity gap is 1.0 FTE."

Subtracting half an FTE from one and a half leaves one FTE.

4. revised assessment

Client: "Friday's commitment is a revised assessment."

The consultant promises an assessment, not completion or authorization of the proposed review.

07 Briefing and language checks

Implementation and Change Management

A Briefing checks / page 58

1. How many managers have demonstrated the required tasks?

D. Four

Four of the ten trained managers have a verified supervised-practice result.

2. What remains unknown for eight managers?

A. Their demonstrated-practice result

Eight lack verified practice results; absence of assessment is not proof of inability.

3. Which launch requirement is entirely unassigned?

A. Operational cover

The brief explicitly states that operational cover has not yet been assigned.

D Language checks / page 63

1. Which readiness statement is accurate?

B. Four have demonstrated the tasks; eight lack verified practice results.

The statement reports the actual practice evidence without confusing missing results with failure or communication with readiness.

2. Which next step addresses the stated gaps?

A. Arrange remaining training, supervised practice, and operational cover before seeking the launch decision.

The stated launch conditions require learning, demonstrated practice, and cover, so each outstanding requirement needs an owned action.

3. What does a usage measure show?

D. Actual use of the defined workflow

Usage concerns behavior in operation and must be distinguished from communication and eventual benefit measures.

4. How should a staged launch be described?

C. A possible revised plan requiring explicit scope, support, cover, and authorization

A smaller start is an option for assessment, not automatic permission to bypass the agreed decision process.

07 Conversation answers

Implementation and Change Management

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 64-65

1. implementation readiness. Turn 2. Launch requires the stated conditions; receiving the announcement establishes only that communication occurred.

2. supervised practice. Turn 4. An observed task result supports readiness; eight missing results do not mean eight people failed.

3. protected time. Turn 6. Time must be set aside for required learning rather than added silently to full workloads.

4. Training completion. Turn 8. Finishing training is separate from demonstrating the tasks under this agreed readiness plan.

5. operational cover. Turn 10. Normal work needs an assigned arrangement while managers prepare; that requirement remains unresolved.

6. readiness gate. Turn 12. A smaller launch still needs its own scope, cover, support, and authorization.

7. process owner. Turn 14. The owner holds ongoing operational responsibility, distinct from the change team's temporary transition support.

8. support model. Turn 16. Named assistance and escalation arrangements prevent reliance on informal personal contacts after launch.

9. adoption. Turn 18. Adoption means actual workflow use, not pre-launch training attendance or receipt of a notice.

10. benefit realization. Turn 20. The intended business result requires evidence beyond training completion or use of the workflow.

F Transfer conversation

Page 66

1. eight supervisors

Lead: "The notice reached eight supervisors."

Receipt of the notice establishes communication to eight people, not completion of the readiness conditions.

2. six supervisors

Owner: "Training is complete for six supervisors."

Six completed the specified learning step, which is separate from demonstrated practice.

3. three supervisors

Lead: "Verified task demonstrations total three supervisors."

Three trained supervisors have demonstrated the tasks under the supplied facts.

4. no verified practice result

Owner: "The five others have no verified practice result, not necessarily failed."

A missing result describes an evidence gap and does not establish inability.

08 Briefing and language checks

Steering Committees and Final Readouts

A Briefing checks / page 67

1. What does the committee agree on?

D. The need to improve service handoffs

Agreement concerns the problem, while the option choice and implementation spending remain unapproved.

2. What did Marta decide at the close?

B. Defer the option choice to Friday at 10:00 local time

The chair explicitly defers the choice to the stated meeting rather than selecting either option.

3. What must Ethan verify by Thursday at 12:00?

D. The system integration position for Option B

Ethan owns the integration follow-up; Nora separately owns Option A staffing confirmation.

D Language checks / page 72

1. Which minute accurately records the meeting?

D. The option decision is deferred to Friday at 10:00; neither option nor additional spending is approved.

The chair deferred the choice and granted no implementation approval, so the record must preserve that status.

2. What is Option B's estimated cost premium over A?

C. \$60,000

Subtracting the eighty-thousand estimate from one hundred forty thousand gives a sixty-thousand premium.

3. Who owns Option A staffing confirmation?

A. Nora

The brief assigns the staffing follow-up specifically to operations lead Nora.

4. Which closing behavior is most useful?

D. Read back the unresolved choice, follow-up owners, deadlines, and approval status.

An explicit read-back preserves what was actually decided and makes the next actions accountable.

08 Conversation answers

Steering Committees and Final Readouts

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 73-74

- 1. consensus.** Turn 2. Agreement concerns the problem, not a selected option or permission to implement it.
- 2. option appraisal.** Turn 4. The comparison must include relevant criteria and unresolved assumptions, not just two prices.
- 3. integration dependency.** Turn 6. Option B's automated reporting relies on a system connection that has not been verified.
- 4. open item.** Turn 8. Option A staffing remains unresolved alongside the integration uncertainty affecting Option B.
- 5. deferred decision.** Turn 10. Deferral moves the choice to Friday without approving either option in the meantime.
- 6. approval status.** Turn 12. Both options and additional implementation spending remain unapproved despite the assigned follow-up actions.
- 7. action owner.** Turn 14. Ethan owns integration verification; Nora owns staffing confirmation, each with the stated deadline.
- 8. trade-off.** Turn 16. Cost and timing must be weighed with reporting capability and feasibility rather than deciding from one figure.
- 9. dissent.** Turn 18. The record preserves substantive disagreements without inventing motives or personal resistance.
- 10. decision log.** Turn 20. The log records deferral, approval status, owners, and deadlines so later readers do not invent authorization.

F Transfer conversation

Page 75

1. deferred

Chair: "The option choice is deferred."

The committee has postponed the choice, not conditionally approved a proposal.

2. Tuesday at 09:00

Presenter: "The next decision time is Tuesday at 09:00."

Tuesday at nine is the explicitly stated time for the option decision.

3. Mei

Chair: "The staffing action owner is Mei."

Mei has the named responsibility for the staffing follow-up.

4. not approved

Presenter: "Additional spending is not approved."

Agreement on the problem and assignment of follow-ups do not authorize extra spending.

08

Find the move you need

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

01 Client Discovery and Problem Definition

Clarify the purpose: What decision should this benchmark help you make?

Confirm the date: The recommendation needs to support the thirtieth-of-November decision.

Check comparability: Are the peer figures based on comparable services and definitions?

Full phrase set: pages 7-8 | Dialogue: pages 10-11

02 Hypotheses and Issue Trees

Keep the explanation provisional: Price is a working hypothesis, not an established churn driver.

Explain overlap: Respondents could name more than one issue.

Look for contradiction: What evidence would weaken the price hypothesis?

Full phrase set: pages 16-17 | Dialogue: pages 19-20

03 Data Requests and Client Burden

Acknowledge the burden: The original list did not distinguish what we need first.

Use existing work: Can the existing reports supply those measures?

Assign an owner: Who can confirm the definition and supply each item?

Full phrase set: pages 25-26 | Dialogue: pages 28-29

04 Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

Lead with the request: We recommend a four-week pilot at one center.

State the evidence level: Walkthroughs suggest a possible benefit; live results are not yet available.

Preserve quality: The error rate must be no higher than two percent under the agreed definition.

Full phrase set: pages 34-35 | Dialogue: pages 37-38

Keep the conversation productive

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

05 Scope Management and Change Requests

Acknowledge the purpose: I understand why Market B has become important.

Describe capacity honestly: The current team cannot complete both full studies by the existing deadline.

Explain an extension: More time is one option, subject to agreement.

Full phrase set: pages 43-44 | Dialogue: pages 46-47

06 Difficult Client Feedback

Acknowledge the miss: You supplied the staffing limit, and we missed it.

Confirm the constraint: The available capacity is half an FTE for this period.

Review the work: We need to identify which tasks and dependencies are affected.

Full phrase set: pages 52-53 | Dialogue: pages 55-56

07 Implementation and Change Management

Separate communication from readiness: Everyone received the announcement, but the launch conditions are not met.

Describe missing evidence fairly: Eight have no verified practice result; that does not mean eight failed.

Keep the gate explicit: Each participant must meet the agreed training and practice conditions.

Full phrase set: pages 61-62 | Dialogue: pages 64-65

08 Steering Committees and Final Readouts

State the shared ground: We agree that the handoff problem needs to be addressed.

State the capability difference: Option A uses manual reporting; Option B proposes automated reporting.

Avoid fictional approval: This is a deferred decision, not an approval subject to checks.

Full phrase set: pages 70-71 | Dialogue: pages 73-74

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

acceptance criterion	agree acceptance criteria	41
access permission	confirm access permissions	24
accountability	demonstrate accountability	51
action owner	name the action owner	69
action title	use an action title	32
adoption	measure process adoption	59
aggregate	use monthly aggregates	23
alternative explanation	test alternative explanations	15
analytical priority	set analytical priorities	15
appendix	move detail to the appendix	33
approval status	state the approval status	69
assumption log	update the assumption log	42
assumption register	update the assumption register	50
automated reporting	assess automated reporting	69
backfill	arrange backfill	60
baseline	establish the baseline	5
benchmark	establish a benchmark	5
benefit realization	track benefit realization	60
bottleneck	locate the bottleneck	51
business-as-usual	maintain business-as-usual service	60
capacity assumption	correct the capacity assumption	50
capacity gap	quantify the capacity gap	50
causal mechanism	specify the causal mechanism	15
caveat	retain the caveat	33

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

centralization	evaluate centralization	5
change authorization	obtain change authorization	41
change champion	support change champions	60
change management	plan change management	59
change register	maintain the change register	42
change request	raise a change request	41
chart annotation	add a chart annotation	33
churn	analyze account churn	14
churn driver	investigate churn drivers	14
client feedback	respond to client feedback	50
client sign-off	obtain client sign-off	51
client sponsor	align with the client sponsor	5
cohort	compare customer cohorts	15
commercial terms	confirm commercial terms	41
comparability	assess comparability	5
completeness	assess completeness	24
conditional approval	distinguish conditional approval	68
confirmation bias	challenge confirmation bias	15
confounder	examine potential confounders	15
consensus	establish the scope of consensus	68
constraint	surface a constraint	6
corrective action	agree corrective action	51
coverage	check period coverage	23
critical task	identify critical tasks	51

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

data dictionary request a data dictionary	23
data minimization apply data minimization	24
data owner identify the data owner	23
data request list prioritize the data request list	23
de-scoping make de-scoping explicit	51
decentralization assess decentralization	5
decision ask clarify the decision ask	32
decision authority confirm decision authority	68
decision criterion agree decision criteria	6
decision criterion prioritize decision criteria	69
decision deadline work to the decision deadline	6
decision log maintain the decision log	68
decision owner identify the decision owner	5
decision pack update the decision pack	69
decision question define the decision question	5
deferral propose deferral	42
deferred decision document a deferred decision	68
deliverable define the deliverable	41
delivery sequence agree the delivery sequence	24
denominator state the denominator	33
dependency identify a dependency	42
depth of analysis specify the depth of analysis	42
disconfirming evidence seek disconfirming evidence	15
discovery conduct client discovery	5

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

discovery record	review the discovery record	50
dissent	record material dissent	68
double counting	prevent double counting	15
DRL	update the DRL	23
dry run	conduct a dry run	59
due time	confirm the due time	69
endorsement	clarify the endorsement	68
engagement charter	confirm the engagement charter	6
evidence chain	check the evidence chain	32
exception log	maintain an exception log	24
executive synthesis	prepare an executive synthesis	32
exhibit	reference the exhibit	32
exit interview	conduct exit interviews	14
extract	prepare a data extract	23
fact check	complete a fact check	50
feasibility	reassess feasibility	50
field definition	confirm field definitions	23
finding	state the finding	32
fixed fee	confirm the fixed fee	41
follow-through	maintain follow-through	51
FTE	calculate available FTE	50
go-live	confirm go-live readiness	59
governing message	state the governing message	32
granularity	agree the required granularity	23

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

guardrail set a quality guardrail	33
handover complete the decision handover	69
high-level scan offer a high-level scan	42
hiring approval confirm hiring approval	51
hypercare plan hypercare	60
hypothesis test a hypothesis	14
hypothesis tree develop a hypothesis tree	14
impact assessment complete an impact assessment	41
implementation estimate qualify the implementation estimate	69
implementation readiness assess implementation readiness	59
implication explain the implication	32
in-scope confirm what is in scope	6
insight develop an insight	32
integration dependency verify the integration dependency	69
issue tree build an issue tree	14
job aid supply a job aid	59
main body keep limits in the main body	33
manual reporting account for manual reporting	69
MECE test a MECE structure	14
median report the median	33
mention count report mention counts	14
minimum viable dataset define the minimum viable dataset	23
minutes confirm the minutes	68
multi-response question interpret a multi-response question	14

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

open item track open items	69
operating model compare operating models	5
operational cover assign operational cover	60
option appraisal complete the option appraisal	68
out-of-scope identify out-of-scope work	6
out-of-scope request assess an out-of-scope request	42
overlap identify category overlap	15
oversight acknowledge the oversight	50
peer group define the peer group	5
pending approval mark the change pending approval	42
personal data limit personal data	24
phasing assess phased delivery	51
pilot authorize a pilot	33
practice environment use a practice environment	59
pre-read circulate the pre-read	33
price sensitivity examine price sensitivity	15
problem statement refine the problem statement	5
process owner confirm the process owner	60
proficiency verify proficiency	59
protected time allocate protected time	59
readiness gate apply the readiness gate	60
readout deliver the final readout	68
recommendation make a recommendation	32
reconciliation reconcile source totals	24

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

record correction	request a record correction	69
reinforcement	provide reinforcement	60
reporting period	specify the reporting period	23
request dependency	identify request dependencies	24
resource availability	check resource availability	41
resource capacity	assess resource capacity	41
resourcing model	revise the resourcing model	50
response time	define response time	6
revision note	include a revision note	51
rework	estimate rework	42
role-based training	provide role-based training	59
rollout decision	separate the rollout decision	33
sample	define the sample	14
sampling bias	assess sampling bias	14
schedule constraint	clarify schedule constraints	51
schedule extension	propose a schedule extension	42
scope baseline	protect the scope baseline	41
scope creep	prevent scope creep	41
scope reduction	evaluate a scope reduction	51
scope trade-off	explain a scope trade-off	42
secure transfer	arrange secure transfer	24
segmentation	use customer segmentation	15
service continuity	assess service continuity	6
source system	identify the source system	24

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

stabilization monitor stabilization	60
staffing constraint acknowledge a staffing constraint	50
staged request use a staged request	24
stakeholder map build a stakeholder map	6
statement of work review the statement of work	41
steady-state cost compare steady-state costs	6
steering committee brief the steering committee	68
storyline build the storyline	32
success criterion agree success criteria	33
success measure agree success measures	6
supervised practice arrange supervised practice	59
support model define the support model	60
supporting evidence present supporting evidence	32
trade-off explain the trade-off	68
training completion record training completion	59
transition cost estimate transition costs	6
triangulation triangulate the finding	15
unit of measure preserve the unit of measure	23
usage measure define usage measures	60
version identifier record the version identifier	24
visual hierarchy improve the visual hierarchy	33
workload assess the workload	50
workstream assign a workstream	14
written variation execute a written variation	42

Original cases. Clear boundaries.

These are original fictional teaching conversations, not transcripts of real workers. Names, figures, organizations, and incidents are invented. Sources support terminology and communication aims, not the fictional results or an endorsement of this book.

[1] McKinsey. How to master the seven-step problem-solving process (2019).

[Open the original source](#)

Background on problem definition, analytical priorities, and synthesis. The cases and language examples are original, not a reproduction of the interview. Checked 1 October 2026.

[2] Association for Project Management. What is change control?

[Open the original source](#)

Terminology distinguishing a requested baseline change from an evaluated and authorized change. Fictional engagement terms supply the exercise decisions. Checked 1 October 2026.

[3] Association for Project Management. What is change management and organisational change?

[Open the original source](#)

Background on organizational adoption and sustained change. Training, practice, ownership, and readiness details in the scenarios are invented. Checked 1 October 2026.

[4] American Society for Quality. What is the Plan-Do-Check-Act cycle?

[Open the original source](#)

Background on small-scale testing and learning before wider change. Pilot thresholds and choices are fictional, not a prescribed professional method. Checked 1 October 2026.

Phil Stilwell

© 2026 Phil Stilwell. All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means without prior written permission from the author, except as permitted by law.

All clients, engagements, people, figures, contracts, policies, and decisions are fictional. This is professional English practice, not legal, financial, statistical, or implementation advice. Real decisions require the applicable evidence, contractual terms, approvals, and qualified review. The cited organizations do not endorse this book.

English Ladder | English for Work | 2026 edition. The B2-C1 range is an editorial study recommendation, not a proficiency certification.

[Open the matching English Ladder course](#)